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Mitigating Burnout in Illinois Human Services Nonprofits: Exploring Leadership Strategies and Human Resource Practices

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DISSERTATION

Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements

For the Degree of Doctor of Education, Ed.D.
Interdisciplinary Leadership, NPSE Concentrations

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Abstract

In this qualitative study, the researcher sought to explore how nonprofit leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout through answering the research question, "What strategies do leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce the burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, and do the servant leadership practices explain the organizational approaches towards the burnout issue?" The researcher conducted semi-structured interviews with five leaders of Chicago-based human services nonprofit organizations to explore the prevalence of burnout, challenges that burnout presents to organizational mission, how they address burnout in their specific contexts, and what lingering challenges that threaten burnout may persist. After conducting thematic analysis, four themes emerged: leadership awareness of the burnout problem, servant leadership behaviors, organizational practices to mitigate burnout, and barriers to burnout mitigation. Within each theme, multiple subthemes were discovered and elaborated upon. Analysis of the study's results revealed that many variables, including organizational size and culture, impacted the feasibility and impact of burnout mitigation; affirmed the importance of servant leadership as a protective factor against burnout; and indicated that measures must be taken at human services nonprofits to proactively anticipate the potential personal and professional challenges that employees may face in order to curb burnout. Future researchers are encouraged to explore the concepts of wellness-oriented leadership, trauma-responsive work environments, and the impact of organizational inclusion practices on burnout.

Keywords: Burnout, nonprofit organizations, nonprofit management, servant leadership, nonprofit leadership

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CHAPTER I: INTRODUCTION

As a result of persistent divestment in the American social safety net, nonprofit organizations in the United States have been made to bear substantial burdens, often beyond what their resources can allow, due to persistent financial, political, and moral pressures (Anheier & Toepler, 2020; Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Oliveira et al., 2021). On an individual level, this often manifests in burnout, a psychological condition in which individuals reach a level of exhaustion that renders them unable to complete their basic duties (Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Lubbadeh, 2020; National Council of Nonprofits, 2023). The purpose of this study is to determine what leaders of human services nonprofits in Chicago presently do to address the risk of burnout at their respective sites. The following chapter will provide a background to the burnout problem as it relates to this study, detail the intentions of the research, and outline the research question and intended audience. The chapter will also explain the assumptions, limitations, and delimitations of this research.

Problem Background

Nonprofit organizations aimed at human services are a vital part of the greater social safety net within the United States. The country's relatively scant access to low-cost healthcare resources leaves many of its most vulnerable people in extremely challenging positions, and leaves many families rudderless (Anheier & Toepler, 2020). Though it is critically important for nonprofit organizations to retain their status as pillars of stability in American society, certain challenges are negatively impacting many nonprofits' ongoing viabilities, including burnout. Among nonprofit employees, burnout is extremely common, owing to low salaries, emotionally taxing work conditions, long hours, and an expectation that the "moral gains" stemming from work should address some of these shortcomings, among other stressors (Robinichau et al.,

2024). In a 2022 survey, nearly one-third of nonprofits with annual operating budgets under $1 million indicated experiencing significant challenges with burnout, with 29.6% of human services nonprofits indicating that burnout and stress are acute challenges in their workplaces (National Council of Nonprofits, 2023).

The National Council of Nonprofits (2023) indicated that more than half of nonprofits with annual operating budgets of under $5 million experience significant challenges with salary competition and that more than a third of human services organizations indicate that salary competition creates significant challenges for recruitment and retention. Nearly a third of nonprofit human services providers indicated that stress and burnout are significant factors impacting their organizations. Furthermore, many nonprofits have experienced failures and unique setbacks due to the increasing pressure that the COVID-19 pandemic placed on safety net organizations in general and were forced to reduce their employees (Oliveira et al., 2021). Recent statistics indicate these challenges with staff retention persist across the nonprofit sector. The average turnover for nonprofit organizations is approximately 20%, compared to the all-industry turnover of 12% (Strub, 2022). In a Forvis Mazars (2024) survey of human services nonprofit leaders, results indicated that challenges with staffing -- specifically, recruitment and retention -- was one of the top challenges reported by nonprofit leaders working between 2023-24, with 74% of nonprofits having a job vacancy. Fears concerning burnout loom large for nonprofit leaders, with 95% of nonprofit leaders and 63% of nonprofit respondents indicating that staff burnout was one of the key challenges their organization faced (Forvis Mazars, 2024; National Council of Nonprofits, 2023).

A comprehensive survey revealed that 63% of Illinois nonprofits are struggling with burnout-related retention challenges (National Council of Nonprofits, 2023), and the voluntary

employee turnover rate in human services organizations was 37%, with the majority of workers making under $40,000 a year (Illinois Partners for Human Service, 2020). Illinois Partners for Human Services (2020) indicated that roughly 80% of turnover in human services organizations was initiated by employees, with nearly half of the turnover occurring in individuals employed at their organization for one year or less, which prevents employees from developing within their organizations, needlessly limiting their growth.

Empirical evidence demonstrates that the pervasive challenges presented by burnout create many psychological and interpersonal blocks that harm the overall productivity and reliability of nonprofit employees (Bayes et al., 2021; Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Lubbadeh, 2020). The unique sets of pressures impacting nonprofit employees also create sets of frustrations related to clarity of mission, work-related responsibility drift, increases in hours, organizational efficacy, and compensation that can encourage burnout (Reichman, 2010; Searing et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2020). Documented human resources approaches within nonprofit organizations have generally been focused on keeping existing staff while steadily cutting pay and adding hours when possible, creating an unsustainable approach to staffing (Oliveria et al., 2021; Searing et al., 2021). Despite these additional burdens being placed on staff members, work-related stress continues to mount in many nonprofit contexts, particularly due to the perception of many nonprofit leaders that followers should view their moral reward as a significant part of their compensation (Palumbo et al., 2022; Robichau et al., 2024).

Research Purpose and Intended Audience

The purpose of this research is to increase understanding of how leaders within human service nonprofit organizations interpret the causes and consequences of burnout and the extent to which they utilize servant leadership principles, such as empathy, stewardship, and

commitment to the growth of others, to support staff well-being. By grounding the analysis in the lived experiences of nonprofit leaders, the study aims to uncover both the strategies employed to mitigate burnout and the structural and cultural barriers that may limit the effectiveness of these strategies. In doing so, the research contributes to the growing body of knowledge on nonprofit leadership and workforce sustainability by highlighting the role of leadership philosophy and practice in addressing occupational stress. Ultimately, the study seeks to generate actionable insights that can inform leadership development, organizational policy, and funding practices in the nonprofit sector.

The study is placed in the context of Illinois human service organizations and is designed to inform and benefit multiple audiences involved in nonprofit leadership, workforce development, and sector sustainability. First and foremost, the findings are intended for nonprofit leaders and executives, including executive directors, senior managers, and board members, particularly those operating within the human services sector. These individuals are uniquely positioned to implement emotionally intelligent leadership strategies and to shape organizational cultures that either exacerbate or alleviate staff burnout. The study offers evidence-based insights to support the adoption of servant leadership principles in daily practice and decision-making.

Second, the research addresses the needs of human resource professionals and organizational development practitioners working in nonprofit settings. As these professionals are responsible for designing and managing policies related to staff wellness, supervision, and professional development, the findings provide actionable guidance for cultivating trauma-informed, burnout-preventive organizational environments. A third critical audience consists of funders, philanthropic institutions, and government grant-making agencies. These actors wield considerable influence over nonprofit operations through their funding priorities and reporting

requirements. The study encourages these stakeholders to reconsider traditional performance metrics and to include staff well-being and leadership capacity-building as core components of grant evaluations and capacity-building initiatives. In addition, the study contributes to the academic discourse and is intended for researchers and scholars in the fields of nonprofit management, organizational behavior, leadership studies, and public administration. By offering empirical findings grounded in servant leadership theory, the study advances the literature on emotionally sustainable leadership models and their application in mission-driven organizations.

This research may also serve as a valuable resource for graduate students and educators in nonprofit studies, organizational leadership, and public affairs programs. It provides a current, real-world case that illustrates the intersection of leadership theory, employee well-being, and structural challenges in the nonprofit sector. As such, it may be used to support curriculum development, class discussions, and student research on leadership and human resource issues. Finally, the study may benefit sector-support organizations and policy advocates that focus on strengthening the nonprofit sector. These entities can utilize the findings to promote policy and systems-level reforms that prioritize employee wellness, inclusive leadership development, and sustainable organizational practices. By addressing the informational needs of these diverse audiences, the study aims to bridge the gap between theory and practice, supporting not only scholarly advancement but also meaningful change in the leadership and sustainability of nonprofit organizations.

Problem Statement

Burnout is a condition in which chronic workplace stress leaves an individual with an inability to perform to the best of their ability, a constant sense of exhaustion, and a desire to detach from their workplace (Edú-Valsania et al., 2022). Evidence demonstrates that nonprofit

organizations, particularly those in the human services sector, are increasingly confronting a workforce crisis marked by chronic employee burnout, high turnover, and diminished well-being (Forvis Mazars, 2024). Research suggests that, while the importance of the role that human services nonprofit organizations play in ensuring that members of vulnerable communities can have their basic needs met is critical, many human services nonprofit employees are at risk of burnout, threatening these organizations' collective viability (Berry et al., 2024; National Council of Nonprofits, 2023; Oliveira et al., 2021). Given the significance of nonprofit organizations in providing services for marginalized and vulnerable populations, it is critically important that they are able to retain highly qualified employees over extended periods of time to ensure that they are well-staffed and prepared to serve those in need (Ciancio, 2021). Scholars argue that while the demands placed on nonprofit workers have intensified due to rising community needs and persistent underfunding, many organizations lack the leadership infrastructure and cultural support necessary to sustain their staff (Robichau et al., 2023).

In order to address the unique sets of challenges faced by nonprofit organizations -- both ongoing and recent - nonprofit researchers and practitioners have called for more pointed interventions on the part of human resources departments within nonprofits, which have not been engaging in practices that adequately support the people working within these important organizations (Berry et al., 2024; Oliveira et al., 2021). Moreover, most research has focused on individual coping mechanisms or organizational policies, rather than examining the leadership practices that shape everyday workplace experiences. While it's necessary for human services nonprofit leaders to become receptive to the emotional and logistical challenges faced by their employees and address them through active servitude (Robichau et al., 2023), there is an

inadequate understanding of how adherence to particular managerial practices within the nonprofit field can help limit burnout and turnover (Mosley et al., 2020).

Research Question

Despite growing attention to burnout as a widespread issue in the nonprofit workforce, there is a lack of understanding of how nonprofit leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout. The servant leadership approach is centered on empathy, stewardship, and the growth of others, and therefore offers a potentially powerful framework for mitigating burnout in mission-driven settings. However, empirical evidence on how nonprofit leaders understand and apply servant leadership to address burnout remains limited, especially in the context of structural constraints such as funding insecurity, emotional labor demands, and blurred staff-volunteer dynamics. This gap in the literature limits both scholarly understanding and practical guidance for nonprofit leaders seeking to foster more supportive and sustainable workplaces. This study proposes to explore how nonprofit leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout through the lens of servant leadership, and how this leadership approach is adapted within the realities of nonprofit work. To achieve its research objective, this study proposes the following research question:

> What strategies do leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce the burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, and do the servant leadership practices explain the organizational approaches towards the burnout issue?

Assumptions

The researcher assumed that the question of burnout would be a key consideration for human services nonprofit leaders, and as such, participants would be able to accurately describe their experiences with managing burnout in their professional lives. The researcher also assumed that human services nonprofit leaders would be able to cogently explain the different manifestations of burnout within their respective organizations, given their robust familiarity with their own organizational structures, communities of beneficiaries, and workforces. Finally, the researcher assumed that participants would be able to truthfully and openly discuss their experiences with the aim of ultimately improving working conditions for nonprofit employees.

Limitations

Qualitative studies are meant to demonstrate a highly subjective, limited understanding of a specific issue with the aim of uncovering information held by those with that perspective (Gay et al., 2012). Participants in this research study were individuals who were in managerial positions within human services nonprofit organizations in the Chicagoland area. The experiences of the participants, as detailed in this study, are strictly applicable to nonprofits that directly serve lower-income individuals in urban areas. Additionally, this study explicitly focused on the experiences of organizational leaders and managers, meaning that the subjective experiences of burnout among employees, volunteers, and other subordinates as detailed here cannot be assigned to those individuals. Though aspects of these experiences may be transferable to human services nonprofit professionals in other urban areas, the testimony of the participants in this study specifically reacts to the circumstances of human services nonprofit stakeholders in Chicago.

Delimitations

This research focused on the experiences and perspectives of human services nonprofit managers located in the Chicagoland area to better understand the causes of burnout, manifestations of burnout, and approaches to circumventing burnout in their shared context. The researcher encouraged participants to reflect on their reasons for their perceptions of burnout, their approaches to burnout, and to hypothesize other approaches that may help improve their means of addressing burnout on an organizational level. The study focused on organizational leaders rather than other types of stakeholders with the aim of understanding the diverse approaches to burnout prevention that human services nonprofits presently use, the perspectives informing those approaches, and the ways in which such approaches may change over time.

Definition of Terms

Beneficiary - In the context of the present study, a beneficiary is anyone who receives direct aid from a human services nonprofit organization, be it in the form of financial aid, housing, or food assistance, as well as assistance in the navigation of governmental institutions.

Burnout - A condition in which an individual experiences negative physical and psychological symptoms as a result of overwork or prolonged periods of distress due to work conditions.

Human services nonprofit - A not-for-profit organization that seeks to help communities meet basic needs relating to food, public safety, medical care, housing, and public advocacy.

Nonprofit leader - For the purposes of this study, this term refers to individuals responsible for the direct management of beneficiary-facing employees within nonprofit organizations.

Servant leadership - Leadership practice that foregrounds the leader's duty and desire to serve their followers, emphasizing empathy, self-knowledge, and humility.

Stakeholder - In the nonprofit context, any individual with a vested interest in the success of a given organization, including, but not limited to, beneficiaries, employees, donors, volunteers, board members, and community members.

Stewardship - A sense of personal responsibility felt for the overall health of the organization and its stakeholders, beyond operational duties.

Chapter Summary

This chapter provided contextual information regarding the issue of burnout within nonprofit organizations that operate in human services. It introduced the research question and outlined the potential relevance of this study to other contexts. Additionally, the chapter defined key terms essential for a comprehensive understanding of the study. The subsequent chapter presents a critical review of the literature related to this research, including existing scholarship on burnout in human services nonprofit organizations and theoretical literature concerning leadership practices. Chapter 3 outlines the methodology employed in this study, detailing the research design, sampling methods, data collection techniques, and data analysis procedures. Chapter 4 presents the study's findings, highlighting the various themes that emerged from the research. Finally, Chapter 5 draws conclusions from the study, connects the findings to the broader literature, and suggests directions for future research and practice.

CHAPTER II: LITERATURE REVIEW

This study examines the issue of burnout within the nonprofit sector, aiming to explore the following research question: What strategies do leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce the burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, and do the servant leadership practices explain the organizational approaches towards the burnout issue? This chapter provides a review of the relevant literature related to the research question, outlining the causes of burnout as well as the types of practices already implemented by human services nonprofit organizations to alleviate it. Furthermore, this chapter introduces the servant leadership theoretical framework that underpins this research, explaining how the principles of servant leadership can be applied to better understand and address the challenges associated with burnout in the nonprofit sector. This chapter presents a review of the literature relevant to the research question, including information on the causes contributing to burnout and the types of practices already used by human services nonprofit organizations to limit burnout.

Research Exploring Burnout

This section explores the historic and current research on burnout within human service nonprofit organizations. It outlines the factors that contribute to burnout, specifically focusing on the causes of burnout in the non-profit sector. Additionally, it discusses the strategies employed by nonprofit leaders to address and manage burnout among their staff.

Factors Leading to Burnout

Burnout refers to the condition of pervasive exhaustion in the workplace, owing to poor organization, high psychological burden, long work hours, and chronic stress (Edú-Valsania et al., 2022). Burnout causes poor indicators of physical health, decreased cognitive function, a sense of hostility towards work, and problems in interpersonal relationships with co-workers and

other professionals. Individuals with burnout experience a variety of physical symptoms, including higher levels of cortisol, lowered immune function, cardiovascular problems, changes in metabolism, and increased instances of mental illness symptoms (Bayes et al., 2021). In terms of behavioral expressions, people experiencing burnout exhibit high levels of cynicism, emotional detachment, and severe physical fatigue, alongside a diminished professional effectiveness.(Lubbadeh, 2020). Burnout can lead to significant increases in absenteeism, employee turnover, and weaker job performances, negatively impacting the quality of organizational performance and discouraging talented employees from making significant contributions to their workplaces (Lubbadeh, 2020).

Burnout is particularly pervasive in nonprofit organizations in recent years, in large part due to a combination of low wages relative to employees' training, a rhetorical emphasis on the importance of self-sacrifice encouraging a poor work-life balance, and the increased burden that pervasive social challenges -- including lagging economies and the COVID-19 pandemic -- have placed on nonprofits (Robichau et al., 2024). Neoliberalism has forced nonprofit organizations to place an emphasis on efficiency and creating quantitative indicators of organizational process at the cost of humanistic approaches, which create meaningful differences in the lives of their dependents (Alexander & Fernandez, 2021). This adds to the sense of frustration, isolation, and unproductivity that pushes nonprofit employees towards burnout. If, as Alexander and Fernandez (2021) and Robichau et al. (2024) indicate, the continual divestment in social programming is creating an increased need for nonprofit organizations, it is critically important to ensure that nonprofit employees are not suffering from burnout and are feeling valued in their work.

Nonprofit Organizational Environment

Nonprofit sector work can be demanding for a wide variety of reasons. Reichman's (2010) taxonomy of challenges faced by nonprofits points to the ambiguities in the responsibilities of nonprofits and governments to advocate for causes, and the mission-related conflicts that can be caused by necessary relationships between nonprofits and their for-profit funders as potential sources of stress on an organizational level. Nonprofits that must take on tasks generally relegated to governments face incredible challenges in terms of the sizes of their undertakings, which may lead to persistent feelings of frustration among employees. Nonprofits that must simultaneously work to serve the conflicting goals of their for-profit funders and their social service missions often exist in spaces of perpetual contradiction, creating a sense of turmoil that may cause increased disenfranchisement among their employees (Edú-Valsania et al., 2022). On a day-to-day level, nonprofit organizations -- particularly those working in human services -- work on extremely limited budgets, involve providing individualized care to individuals in extremely dire sets of circumstances, often work in situations where quick action is required to adequately care for beneficiaries, and are regularly overburdened by the size of their beneficiary bases (Shi et al., 2020).

Human services nonprofit employees are often driven by a sense of self-sacrifice that is both viewed as a "natural" aspect of the human services nonprofit employee profile and a point of pressure for organizational leaders, exacerbating the burnout problem (McClure & Moore, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021). The remedies to problems of funding and organizational performance commonly faced by nonprofit organizations often end up with requests for employees to sacrifice their time or money in service of the organization (Kuenzi et al., 2021; Olivera et al., 2021; Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021).

These convergences of conflicting interests, limited resources, the necessity of difficult partnerships, the incredible emotional burden of working with people in tragic circumstances, and the high volume-related demands placed on nonprofits result in an incredibly stressful work environment. All of these different vectors for conflict and disenfranchisement cannot be easily reconciled; even effective nonprofit organizations commonly expect staff members to work for reduced pay, run into regular problems with securing additional funding -- particularly during periods of increased demand for services -- and find themselves progressively overburdened with beneficiaries for whom they cannot adequately provide (Searing et al., 2021). Many nonprofit employees are constantly placed in a position at the crossroads of ethical compromise, undercompensation, and the nagging sense that their lack of adequate commitment may be the problem, creating an ideal set of circumstances for burnout (Lubbadeh, 2020).

Burnout and Work-Related Stress

Research suggests that professionals working within nonprofit organizations are often put in compromising positions as a result of the stated self-sacrificial commitments of their organizations. Keeping in mind that much of the human services nonprofit work is based around providing aid to people in dire and tragic circumstances, this leads to circumstances that can encourage burnout in nonprofit employees. Robichau et al. (2023) argued that while it is true that many nonprofit employees are motivated at least in part by the sense of reward that accompanies doing good for particular groups, communities, or causes, many feel that an emphasis on cause-driven impact is viewed as a type of compensation with an overdetermined value. This overdetermination often leads to a kind of emotional manipulation on the part of managers, who posit that the “psychic income” that employees receive is as or more valuable than other types of “compensation” that contribute to quality of life, such as income, time off, and schedule-related

flexibility. This builds resentment in nonprofit employees and gives nonprofit leaders a means of dodging reasonable expectations regarding work conditions. This is demonstrated in Searing et al.'s (2021) account of a wide-reaching funding-related problem existing within the nonprofit community at large, wherein individual employees were expected to sacrifice their own livelihoods in service of their organization's missions, visions, and stability. These perceptions of nonprofit employees as fundamentally manipulable and so wholly committed to service that they do not seek economic stability are wildly misguided and put nonprofit organizations at risk of investing in strong workers who seek to leave when they gain the opportunity (Robichau et al., 2024).

Burnout can come about due to a great variety of contributing conditions and factors. Palumbo et al. (2022) explored the implications of time-based stressors identified in Robichau et al. (2024) more in-depth. For the purposes of this study, "time-related work stress" is characterized as stress stemming from limitations in workers' abilities to complete the tasks that they have been given. Because of the nature of nonprofit organizations' beneficiary bases, the unique sets of challenges that working with underprivileged populations presents, and nonprofit organizations' self-sacrificial identities, there exists a tendency on the part of nonprofit managers to impose sudden or highly time-sensitive tasks on their employees. The researchers sought to explore the impact of time-related work stress within the nonprofit sector on employees' frequency of work-life conflicts and levels of work engagement. Both of these perceptions can contribute to burnout, owing to the fact that short turnaround periods for highly complicated and emotionally taxing tasks can build profound senses of work-related and emotional fatigue. These findings mirror those of Kuenzi et al. (2021), which also point to the overlapping sets of stressors impacting nonprofit employees, including those directly related to time-based limitations.

The expectations of self-sacrifice discussed in Robichau et al. (2024) and Searing et al. (2021) push overworked nonprofit employees to find systems of support within the workplace that are both based in mutual understanding and readily accessible. In many instances, this means that nonprofit employees depend on each other for professional support to help cope during periods of acute stress. McClure and Moore (2021) studied the impact of peer support on levels of stress faced by nonprofit workers. The researchers conducted a survey that focused on 93 workers at 15 different nonprofit organizations that revealed that many nonprofit employees have important relationships with their coworkers that help them regulate their stress levels. Though this suggests that teamwork within the nonprofit sector has positive impacts on managing the conditions that encourage burnout, it also demonstrates how policies that do not adequately support nonprofit employees can create cascading burdens within organizations. This "bottom-up" design of employee support creates an outsized burden on the lower rungs of the organization, which poses additional questions relating to the long-term sustainability of nonprofit organizations. In line with the questions posed by Robichau et al. (2024), there are limits to the amount of support that nonprofit employees can reasonably expect to give, and failing to recognize that in service of maintaining a baseline of care begets greater precarity in these important institutions.

Nonprofit Human Resources Practices

In addition to the significant financial and organizational challenges routinely being faced by nonprofits of all kinds, the current body of literature suggests that many human services nonprofits place excessive pressure on their employees to downplay their own needs in service of the needs of their organizations, creating an unsustainable pattern of self-sacrifice that often encourages burnout (McClure & Moore, 2021; National Council of Nonprofits, 2023; Robichau

et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021). Research suggests that nonprofit employees are experiencing low levels of job satisfaction and are often opting to leave their professions (Robinichau et al., 2024). Despite their expertise in their respective professional roles, nonprofit employees are commonly disempowered in their day-to-day work due to highly prescriptive, standardized approaches to interventions that discount their informed opinions (Mosley et al., 2020). These frustrations are particularly challenging for employees who come from historically marginalized groups, including women and members of ethnic minority groups, who are often subjected to unjust professional expectations, stereotype risk, microaggressions, and other professional stressors that dissuade their ongoing workplace engagement (Clary & Rose, 2022; Rendon, 2024). In a study exploring the impacts of COVID-19 on nonprofit workers, Kuenzi et al. (2021) indicated that there exists relatively little focused study on the impact of human resources policies on nonprofits. Although the COVID-19 pandemic does not necessarily provide an objective window for indicating the baseline levels of organizational and personal stress experienced by nonprofit employees, the additional challenges that the pandemic caused for nonprofits allowed for many of the shortcomings of the nonprofit infrastructure to be exposed.

The researchers argued that human resources practices impacting nonprofit employees, such as reductions in work hours, pay cuts, changes in work expectations, and growing demand for nonprofit services, may, in many cases, dissuade nonprofit workers from continuing their involvement within the sector. The “double bind” of increases in organizational demands and decreases in adequate organizational resources creates an intensely challenging set of experiences for nonprofit employees, who are often subject to emotionally and psychologically draining types of tasks. The researchers emphasized that one of the most glaring omissions in the existing body of work is the nonprofit employee voice, including the perceptions of human

resources workers. This sense of disempowerment can push strong, dedicated nonprofit employees out of the field, where their unique sets of competencies and skills can be appreciated and compensated in the ways they feel are warranted.

In a quantitative study examining the influence of strategic human resources practices on 242 religion-based nonprofits, Olivera et al. (2021) indicated that there are five key subdimensions of human resource practice within nonprofit organizations: motivation, performance, practices, tools to support training and volunteering. Per Kuenzi et al. (2021), many nonprofits appear to be performing poorly due to a dearth of measures aimed at maintaining motivation and supporting ongoing training. The researchers in Olivera et al. (2021) indicated that many nonprofit organizations are not vehicles for open innovation because managerial leaders, internal stakeholders, and external stakeholders view the work of nonprofits as essentially stability seeking: to change managerial practices is to introduce risk, and the ostensible goal of nonprofits is to minimize said risk. Consequently, there exists a fundamental resistance towards change that may create obstacles to improvement for many human resources leaders at nonprofit organizations. In line with the discussion of nonprofit employee experiences in Kuenzi et al. (2021), when an organization that seeks to act as a pillar of stability for a group of people who are experiencing profound personal challenges, its employees are expected to bend to the wills and needs of those they serve. The organization is not expected to adjust to the needs of its employees. This, ironically, can lead to a sense of resentment and isolation based on a lack of individual consideration, completely at odds with the stated intentions of human services nonprofits.

The challenges discussed in Oliveira et al. (2021) and Kuenzi et al. (2021), in tandem, demonstrate that it is crucial for human services nonprofit organizations to find ways to retain

their valued staff and create work environments based on ongoing mutual support in spite of their limited resources and risk-aversion. In the interest of exploring the sources of nonprofit resilience, Searing et al. (2021) conducted interviews with 31 Illinois-based nonprofits that focused on their experiences during the Illinois state budget impasse. This impasse occurred between 2015 and 2017, during which time the legislative branch of the Illinois state government continually failed to pass a budget due to continual political gridlock, creating tremendous problems for nonprofit organizations that relied upon the distribution of federal funding to maintain their daily operations. After conducting thematic analysis, the researchers indicated that human resources departments are among the most vital for creating resilient nonprofit organizations but can easily mishandle situations in ways that are profoundly counterproductive for organizational health. The researchers indicated that reducing staff is generally a poor tactic for increasing organizational resilience due to high levels of collaboration between staff members, limited financial capability for hiring, and a highly contested labor market.

Human resources workers often tried to circumvent these problems by not paying staff, requiring staff to work extra hours as volunteers, or rewarding staff with flexible hours. The former two tactics in particular placed an additional burden on staff, creating added stress and resentment. This speaks to the sense of abiding disenfranchisement experienced by nonprofit staff, as discussed in Oliveira et al. (2021), and speaks to the negative aspects of the risk aversion discussed in Kuenzi et al. (2021). The intentions of nonprofit work attract people who view some degree of self-sacrifice as something fundamentally valuable. Yet when organizational leadership and human resources departments view highly qualified staff as solely driven by the improvement of a tenacious social problem, the stability of these vitally important organizations is threatened.

Strategies Used to Limit Burnout Among Nonprofit Employees

Even though burnout-related turnover is a significant problem facing the nonprofit sector, there is a significant gap in the literature as it relates to processes used to limit burnout among nonprofit employees (McClure & Moore, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024). Very little has been published concerning the human resources-related approaches that have been used to address this problem. In a study of the human resources practices of 229 charitable nonprofit organizations, Guo et al. (2010) found that strategic human resources management was more widely used by wealthier, better-established organizations with the capability to outsource work tasks to contractors. This suggests that smaller organizations, which may have a more intimate understanding of certain groups that need to receive aid, the struggles of residents of a particular area, or other types of specific knowledge that may help in the provision of human services, may face significant organizational disadvantages that limit the reach of effective, holistic approaches. Nonprofits with a greater understanding of how to incorporate technology into their work were also found to be more likely to incorporate strategic human resources management practices, as were nonprofits that lacked a dedicated human resources department. This suggests that smaller nonprofits may be able to organize internal human resources strategies that are effective without dedicated human resources employees. However, this may also suggest that nonprofits must seek to hire a complicated strategy in an industry that is so deeply steeped in risk aversion.

Due to the dearth of academic studies focusing on the experiences of human services nonprofit employees, it is difficult to find studies that deeply explore what drives their intention towards turnover. This significant gap in the literature prompted the researcher to seek out information on other types of turnover intention relating to nonprofit organizations. In a study of

turnover intention among volunteers working for nonprofit organizations, De Clerck et al. (2021) found that chaotic leadership styles -- in which leaders lack a clear sense of structure in what they ask of the people who serve them -- a lack of clearly expressed need on the part of nonprofit leaders, and a lack of support that encouraged autonomy all led to increases in turnover intentions. The researchers indicated that increasing the level of openness to volunteer collaboration and the level of individual consideration -- in line with the tenets of servant leadership, as expressed by Greenleaf (2007) -- would be advisable for nonprofit leaders. Though this study does not directly deal with nonprofit employees, it can be reasonably inferred that these types of organizational deficiencies are likely to have similar stems. De Clerck et al.'s (2021) characterizations of inadequately prepared nonprofit leaders alienating devoted workers echo the types of discord found in Kuenzi et al. (2021), Robichau et al. (2024), and Searing et al. (2021), in which nonprofit employees were continually asked to engage in self-sacrificial behaviors as a means of sustaining organizations under perpetual financial duress. The chaotic leadership styles characterized in De Clerck et al. (2021) demonstrate the types of hurried and unconsidered managerial oversight that can result from a perpetual feeling of insecurity on the part of leadership. Overall, this suggests that it is imperative for nonprofit managers to impart a sense of structure and intention in their dealings with subordinates.

In addition to clearer structural boundaries, placing formal limitations on work demands has been theorized to improve the experiences of nonprofit employees. In a phenomenological study focusing on the experiences of individuals working within human services nonprofits, Cianco (2021) indicated that time-based limitations on caseloads and daily expectations for task completion, as well as the provision of break time, were thought to have positive implications for employee burnout. Though these recommendations do mirror those made, explicitly or

implicitly, in Robichau et al. (2024) and Searing et al. (2021), in all cases, these are solely recommendations based on observations of common challenges, and are not based on the results of experimental studies. Cianco (2021) also indicated that leaders with high levels of demonstrated commitment to their employees were able to encourage said employees to overcome significant work-related obstacles to a greater degree than leaders who were less actively involved in their employees' development. While this does echo the points expressed in De Clerck et al. (2021), this speaks more to the general need for a sense of security to exist within these organizations than a concrete sense of guidance.

In short, Cianco (2021), De Clerck et al. (2021), and Guo et al. (2010) all demonstrate a lacking sense of urgency among nonprofit leaders and nonprofit to make concrete steps to address the challenges facing their employees. Though there appears to be a common cognizance that nonprofit organizations are facing problems with sustainability as it relates to human resources retention, there is limited information on how different kinds of nonprofits adjust to these circumstances. This creates a profoundly concerning dynamic for the human services nonprofit field and for the nonprofit field in general, as nonprofits and their workers are critically important social safety nets whose contributions must be valued and sustained to the greatest extent possible.

Leadership Theory and Burnout

Leadership theory provides a means through which a possible solution to these questions of burnout in nonprofit organizations can emerge. Multiple studies found a connection between burnout with leadership. Muse (2018) used a correlational research design to analyze survey data from Family Justice Center Alliance organizations in the United States. These organizations help address issues of domestic violence and sexual assault in areas all over the United States. Using

Likert-style survey data, Pearson moment correlations, and multiple linear-regression analysis to explore the statistical data, the researcher found that self-reported levels of hope towards organizational success, agency thinking, pathways thinking, and hope in leaders all limited nonprofit employees' self-reported levels of burnout, particularly as it related to exhaustion and disengagement. Leaders' levels of hope did not demonstrate any significant difference in burnout, suggesting that, within nonprofit organizations, employees' perceptions of leaders may be more significant than leaders' own views. In some ways, this speaks to Cianco's (2021) conclusions concerning the importance of how employees understand their leaders' commitments to organizational success and commitments to their employees. As discussed earlier, Ciancio (2021) used a phenomenological approach to explore the experiences of nonprofit employees working in direct human service as they related to burnout, with an emphasis on the mediating factors of leadership style. The researcher found that individuals working in nonprofit capacities generally found that open communication and support from individuals working in leadership create a sense of loyalty and commitment to the organization and its cause. This connection with leaders may occur at any level within the organizational hierarchy; leaders in charge of the organization and direct supervisors may both be vectors for this type of meaningful institutional care.

Focusing on the challenges facing women in nonprofit organizations during the COVID-19 pandemic, Clary and Rose (2022) argued that nonprofit leaders' lack of focus of sustaining quality of life for their employees and a lingering perception of women in nonprofits as self-sacrificial creates patterns of manipulation that place the onus of care solely on employees rather than on leaders. The researchers indicate that the self-sacrificial narratives which define the relationships between nonprofit employees and their employers speak to the perceptions of care-

adjacent professions in general as essentially feminine and existing in a space of subservience to male-coded organizational leaders. This amplifies the challenges presented to employees of nonprofit organizations, as demonstrated in the descriptions of leadership-employee relations in both Oliveira et al. (2021) and Kuenzi et al. (2021), and further demonstrated the ethical challenges which accompany the types of expectations given to nonprofit employees at large, as discussed in Robichau et al. (2024). Clary and Rose (2022) demonstrate how these socially prescribed relationships of submission prevent nonprofit employees from gaining the leverage and power that they need to create more sustainable futures for themselves and their organizations.

Speaking to the deficits in employee-focused care hinted at in Clary and Rose (2022), research suggests that more humanistic leadership styles can help improve nonprofit organizations' functional capacities. Lasrado and Kassem (2021) conducted a study on how transformational leadership and organizational culture impact organizational performance. The researchers used a questionnaire-based tool and modeling practices to determine the extent to which leadership practices were connected with organizational excellence. The researchers found that survey data suggested a culture in which leaders holistically engage employees engenders high levels of inclusivity and participation, which in turn improves the overall quality of work. This speaks to the importance of creating an organizational culture of openness and participation, as discussed in Greenleaf (2007), and as is suggested in the work of De Clerck et al. (2021). Suggested human resources practices aimed at limiting burnout that exist in the present literature widely align with the tenets of servant leadership, as defined by Greenleaf (2007).

Theoretical Framework

This section examines the theoretical foundations of servant leadership theory and its implications for the burnout issues in the nonprofit sector. It also outlines servant leadership practices and highlights the significance of this theory in relation to the research objectives.

Servant Leadership Theory

Servant leadership theory contends that for leaders to be effective, they must make an effort to get in contact with their followers and their unique sets of needs so they can give them the types of personalized support necessary to be effective in their work (Eva et al., 2019). The philosophy driving servant leadership is highly influenced by history, with key focuses being placed on historical figures who have broken from displaying boundless power in order to demonstrate subject-focused benevolence; examples of case studies previously cited in the literature include Jesus Christ, Frederick the Great, Augustus II the Strong, and more recently, Pope Francis (Eva et al., 2019; Langhof & Guldenberg, 2020).

The foundational text of servant leadership is Robert Greenleaf's (2007) "Servant as Leader," which argues that a great leader must be defined by their servitude -- a servitude that responds to a genuine desire within to pay tribute to the people whom they are serving -- in order to both gain legitimacy and to empower their followers. Greenleaf contends that a desire to serve must precede and supersede the desire to lead, because the desire to serve places individuals in a position that cultivates empathy, self-knowledge, humility, and greater understanding of the world. This speaks to De Clerck et al.'s (2021) discussions of the importance of nonprofit organizational leaders creating trusting relationships with their followers.

Through the acknowledgement of the limitation of one's own perspective, the desire to build new systems that empower others, and a goal based in one's own knowledge and

competence, one can simultaneously gain power and carry out servitude. Greenleaf's (2007) model focuses on empowering the truly benevolent and selfless and envisions a world where it is this selflessness that -- through building followers impassioned by this selflessness -- cumulatively drives change. Through a critical analysis of various writings on servant leadership, Pawar et al. (2020) found that the particular manifestations and definitions of servant leadership have been somewhat loosely defined in the existing literature, particularly across different cultural contexts. Contrary to the authors' contentions, this does not demonstrate a fundamental weakness with the theory of servant leadership; rather, it demonstrates the fluidity and essential durability of the theory across different organizational and national boundaries that Greenleaf (2007) initially sought to cultivate. In truth, it could be argued that servant leadership's cultural amorphousness allows for the school of thought to transfer into a variety of contexts, potentially creating spaces for new types of intercultural connection within a diverse and growing nonprofit organization community.

Across these boundaries, servant leaders seek to cultivate practices that emphasize individualized shows of respect, high levels of collaboration, and open confirmation of followers' skills and abilities (Sturm, 2008). Boone and Makhani (2012) indicated that in order to be successful, servant leaders must emphasize the importance of creating a changeable vision, must be highly active listeners, must be committed to the success of others on their own terms, must place an emphasis on deferring their power elsewhere, and must build community. Rather than building a clear vision of what success looks like and demanding that followers defer their power to a vision determined by the leader, servant leaders provide a general concept of success that can be collectively determined and reshaped by the unique and intrinsic abilities that the leader identifies in others. In conversation with Sturm (2008) and Boone and Makhani (2012), Spears

emphasizes the importance of listening, commitment to the growth of people, and healing for the servant leader. In other words, per Spears (2012), the servant leader does not seek to prescribe their followers to particular roles, rather, the servant leader seeks to create systems of relation which foster self-realization through meeting followers on their own levels, affirming their perceptions of themselves and their abilities while seeking to realize their potential on the terms of the group-mediated organizational mission. This has direct applicability to the issue of nonprofit burnout because this individualized consideration, emphasis on empathy, and visible dedication to individual growth plays into the types of humanistic aims traditionally emphasized within nonprofits. Additionally, research has shown that adoption of servant leadership practices can be used to help address employee burnout within organizations, further suggesting the importance of adopting such practices (Divya & Suganthi, 2018).

Servant Leadership Practices

Research has suggested that servant leadership practices within nonprofit organization work contexts have positive impacts on stakeholders' levels of organizational commitment, workplace engagement, and identification with the organization. The following section will highlight the different ways in which servant leadership practices have been found to meaningfully contribute to the success of nonprofit organizations and organizations more generally. It merits mentioning that the dearth of studies concerning the impact of servant leadership on human services nonprofits prompted a more holistic approach to the evaluation of the utility of the practice.

In a critical literature review, Gabriel and Aguinis (2021) indicated that the strongest approaches to limiting burnout are creating interventions for stress management, providing employees with autonomy in their work, building a culture of mutual social support, seeking out

employee voice in decision-making, and implementing performance management practices. This widely echoes the sentiments discussed in Greenleaf (2007), in which servant leaders are instructed to create opportunities for self-direction and demonstrate care to their followers, and contrasts deeply with the lack of individual employee autonomy discussed in Kuenzi et al. (2021) and Searing et al. (2021).

Stankeviciute and Savaneviciene (2019) conducted a quantitative study that explored the link between human resources management practices, stress, and burnout, based on a survey of 376 business professionals. The researchers indicated that human resources management practices in work settings were linked to decreases in work-family conflict and employee burnout. Human resources management practices here included developing employees' competencies, including employee voice in decision making, and demonstrating care for employees. This demonstrates how servant leadership practices can encourage the development of affirming and human-centered work contexts, in stark contrast with the present sets of nonprofit business practices described in the works of Robichau et al. (2024) and Clary and Rose (2022).

In a grounded theory-based study of 31 different Pennsylvania-based nonprofits, Shier and Handy (2020) found that internal stakeholder engagement that actively seeks out employee voice, creates opportunities for shared decision-making, and focuses on development-driven retention -- all concepts in line with the tenets of servant leadership, as identified in Greenleaf (2007) -- all resulted in positive long-term gains for nonprofits.

Using structural equation modeling based on data collected from 309 nonprofit employees, Aboramadan et al. (2022) found that demonstration of servant leadership behaviors positively impacted employees' levels of creativity, innovative work behavior, and

organizational citizenship behavior. This demonstrates greater levels of nonprofit employee engagement and a heightened level of critical thinking concerning their (i.e. employees') capacities for effecting change within their work contexts.

Ngah et al. (2022) indicated that servant leadership practices are connected to increases in volunteer retention and organizational citizenship behavior, suggesting a greater sense of unity and role commitment stemming from individualized consideration. Given the critical importance of volunteer labor within nonprofit organizations, and given that volunteer labor must be driven by a sense of organizational identification and commitment, this has relevance to the current topic. Using MANOVA-based comparisons of the impact of servant leadership in nonprofit and for-profit contexts on 254 employees, Amir et al. (2021) found that servant leadership practices are more impactful on employee performance in nonprofit contexts, likely owing to a greater level of alignment with the essential tenets of nonprofit work and due to its religious origins, as alluded to in Eva et al. (2019) and Langhof & Guldenberg (2020). Both of these studies contrast deeply with De Clerck et al.'s (2021) depiction of organizations with low volunteer buy-in as a result of poor managerial practices.

Research on strategies used to limit nonprofit burnout is fairly limited, however, existing literature suggests that when leaders demonstrate high levels of individualized consideration, employees demonstrate a higher level of resilience and a greater ability to overcome work-related challenges (Cianco, 2021; De Clerck et al., 2021; Guo et al., 2010; Lasrado & Kassem, 2021). These findings were broadly found to be in line with servant leadership theory's emphasis on individualized consideration, the importance of empathetic perceptions of followers, and the creation of a cohesive community, among other aspects (Boone & Makhani, 2012; Eva et al., 2019; Greenleaf, 2007; Sturm, 2008) Overall, this body of research suggests that servant

leadership practices may be helpful in informing the development of a nonprofit human resources approach that limits employee turnover.

Synthesis of Literature

The literature on burnout in the nonprofit sector underscores a multifaceted and persistent challenge. Burnout, a condition in which individuals experience pervasive exhaustion in the workplace, has negative implications for organizational staffing, employee health outcomes, and organizational performance (Bayes et al., 2021; Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Lubbadeh, 2020). Burnout is deeply rooted in systemic and organizational factors such as chronic underfunding, excessive workloads, emotional labor, time-based stressors, and the ideological emphasis on self-sacrifice among nonprofit workers. These issues are exacerbated by unstable funding environments, neoliberal efficiency demands, and a professional culture that valorizes unpaid or underpaid labor, especially among historically marginalized groups (Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021; Clary & Rose, 2022). Scholars have identified the physical, emotional, and psychological toll of these stressors (Edú-Valsania et al., 2022; Bayes et al., 2021), as well as their detrimental impact on job satisfaction, retention, and organizational performance (Lubbadeh, 2020; Kuenzi et al., 2021).

This is a common problem in human services nonprofits in the United States, owing to the consistent divestment, devaluation, and privatization that has characterized the country's approach to social services in the last half-century, as well as the profoundly emotional dimensions of human services nonprofit work (Alexander & Fernandez, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2020).

Relatively little is known in terms of how nonprofit organizations mitigate burnout rates among employees, owing to the survivalist streak in the nonprofit managerial world (De Clerck

et al., 2021; Guo et al., 2010). Some scholars have found that particular approaches towards managerial practice, particularly those that foreground quality of life in employees, can help limit levels of burnout (Cianco, 2021; Clary & Rose, 2022; Muse, 2018). While various coping strategies and HR practices are cited in the literature, such as peer support (McClure & Moore, 2021), workload adjustment (Cianco, 2021), and employee inclusion (Oliveira et al., 2021), these remain underdeveloped, unevenly applied, and rarely grounded in a coherent leadership philosophy. Moreover, most of the existing empirical work focuses on structural stressors or organizational responses in isolation, with limited attention to how leadership practices, particularly those that prioritize care and empowerment, shape employee experiences and organizational resilience.

Despite growing acknowledgment of the burnout crisis, the literature reveals a clear gap in empirically grounded, leadership-focused frameworks that address burnout prevention and mitigation in human services nonprofits. Studies highlight the need for leadership styles that affirm individual contributions, foster inclusion, and promote emotional well-being, particularly in organizations where employees are at heightened risk for burnout due to value-driven labor and resource scarcity. Servant leadership theory, which foregrounds the importance of individualized support for followers and the need to determine what drives employees towards success in order to engender a culture of care, may provide a means of addressing these challenges (De Clerck et al., 2021; Eva et al., 2019; Langhof & Guldenberg, 2020; Pawar et al., 2020). Some scholarship indicates that servant leadership practices can be used to limit employee stress within nonprofits and create more supportive work cultures (Aboramadan et al., 2022; Amir et al., 2021; Gabriel & Aguinis, 2021; Ngah et al., 2022; Stankeviciute & Savaneviciene, 2019).

While servant leadership is frequently suggested as a potential remedy (Greenleaf, 2007; Spears, 2012), few studies have systematically explored its application in nonprofit settings to understand how it might reorient managerial practices toward sustaining workforce well-being. Much of the empirical support for servant leadership exists in adjacent fields or generic organizational contexts (e.g., business, volunteer management, or education), and not within the unique, high-stakes environments of human services nonprofits. Where servant leadership is mentioned (e.g., De Clerck et al., 2021; Shier & Handy, 2020), its impact is often inferred rather than directly studied, and research tends to emphasize volunteers or generalized workplace attitudes rather than frontline employees grappling with burnout.

This study addresses the above gap by exploring how servant leadership practices manifest in human services nonprofit organizations as a response to employee burnout. Using Greenleaf's (2007) theoretical foundation, the study seeks to answer the research question, "What strategies do leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce the burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, and do the servant leadership practices explain the organizational approaches towards the burnout issue?" To answer the research question, the study frames servant leadership not only as a leadership style, but as a strategic orientation rooted in empathy, empowerment, and collective responsibility. Specifically, it investigates how leaders' commitment to individualized care, employee voice, and professional development affects staff experiences of burnout and informs organizational approaches to managing stress and sustaining morale.

By focusing on the nonprofit context, where servant leadership's principles align closely with sectoral values but are not systematically implemented, this study contributes both theoretically and practically. Theoretically, it tests the applicability and relevance of servant

leadership in a domain with complex structural constraints and high emotional demands. Practically, it offers to nonprofit leaders the evidence-informed guidance on how to cultivate supportive workplace cultures that prioritize employee well-being without compromising mission-driven goals. In doing so, the study responds to calls for more humanistic and inclusive leadership models (Lasrado & Kassem, 2021; Amir et al., 2021), while situating burnout not merely as an individual failing or HR issue, but as a symptom of deeper organizational and leadership challenges that can be mitigated through servant leadership practices.

Chapter Summary

This chapter presented a comprehensive review of scholarly literature on employee burnout within human services nonprofit organizations, identifying both the structural causes of burnout and the organizational strategies used to address it. The chapter began by exploring the definition and symptoms of burnout, emphasizing its physical, emotional, and professional toll on nonprofit workers. Burnout was attributed to a combination of sector-specific challenges: underfunding, unrealistic workloads, role ambiguity, emotional labor, and a cultural expectation of self-sacrifice. The pressures created by external forces, such as neoliberal efficiency models and crises like the COVID-19 pandemic, further exacerbated these stressors, leading to high rates of staff turnover, disillusionment, and disengagement.

The review highlighted how nonprofit environments often placed employees in conflicting roles—simultaneously expected to provide high-quality services with limited resources while sacrificing their well-being for the organization's mission. While peer support and informal coping mechanisms proved effective at times, the literature revealed that human resources practices across the sector were inconsistent, reactive, and rarely grounded in strategic

leadership models. Limited attention was given to employee voice, especially among staff from marginalized communities, further undermining workplace equity and engagement.

Importantly, the chapter identified a critical gap in the research: although many studies called for leadership approaches that prioritized empathy, collaboration, and staff empowerment, few investigated how leadership theories could be applied to directly address burnout. In response, the chapter introduced servant leadership as a promising theoretical framework. Rooted in the work of Greenleaf (2007), servant leadership emphasized the moral imperative of leaders to serve, support, and empower their staff. This model stood in contrast to the dominant leadership practices in the sector, which often reflected hierarchical, risk-averse, or transactional norms. The review found that servant leadership principles—such as active listening, fostering autonomy, affirming employee voice, and promoting shared decision-making—were strongly aligned with the conditions necessary to reduce burnout, yet remained underutilized in empirical research on nonprofits.

Building on the findings and gaps identified in the literature review, the next chapter will present the study's research design. It will explain the qualitative methodology used to explore how nonprofit leaders in human service organizations in the Chicago area apply servant leadership principles to prevent and mitigate staff burnout.

CHAPTER III: METHODOLOGY

This study employed an exploratory qualitative research design to answer the following research question: What strategies do leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce the burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, and do the servant leadership practices explain the organizational approaches towards the burnout issue? Chapter 3 describes the research methodology, and includes a description of research design, participant selection, data collection methods, and the analytical approach used to uncover themes related to leadership behaviors and employee well-being. Finally, the chapter outlines ethical considerations as well as the approaches taken to ensure reliability and validity of the study's results.

Research Design

To assess the impact of servant leadership styles among leaders in human services nonprofits on employee turnover, this study utilized an exploratory qualitative case study approach. Exploratory research represents a non-experimental inquiry aimed at establishing a foundational understanding of a phenomenon that has not been thoroughly examined, thereby enhancing researchers' ability to engage in an emerging field of study (Stebbins, 2001). In high-quality exploratory qualitative research, the investigator identifies a process through which they anticipate gaining insights into the phenomenon, followed by qualitative data collection and analysis to further that exploration (Mansourian, 2007). The perceptions of nonprofit leaders regarding the prevalence and causes of burnout, along with strategies for mitigating it within their organizations, were explored through a series of semi-structured interviews.

This qualitative research method involves the researcher posing a set of predetermined questions while retaining the flexibility to adapt their inquiries based on relevant topics that

emerge during the interview process (Mansourian, 2007). By capturing these diverse perspectives, the study aimed to generate a comprehensive body of information that could enable nonprofit leaders to critically evaluate various approaches to enhance organizational support for their employees, ultimately increasing the likelihood of success and sustainability for human services nonprofits.

Research Participants

To examine the effects of leadership style on burnout and turnover in the nonprofit sector, this study focused on leaders of nonprofit human services organizations—such as chief operating officers and presidents—operating in Illinois. Exploring the relationship between nonprofit leadership style and employee burnout necessitates engagement with the leaders who establish their workplace's culture, foster relationships with their staff, and shape the social dynamics of their organizations (Spears, 2010). This is especially relevant when investigating the concept of servant leadership, as it hinges on the relationships cultivated between organizational leaders and their team members (Sturm, 2008). By conducting the research within a consistent state context, the researcher could ascertain that participants' organizations face similar legislative pressures and, in many cases, particularly among organizations in Chicago, serve comparable populations.

The leaders of human services nonprofits in the Chicagoland area serve as the focus of this study due to their regular engagement with nonprofit employees and their deep understanding of the organizational challenges posed by turnover. Many of these leaders have previously worked in direct client-care roles, providing them with firsthand knowledge of the stressors faced by both clients and beneficiaries. Moreover, they are acutely aware of the contradictory impulses inherent in managing a human services organization. The significance of

the Chicagoland setting lies in its cultural and economic diversity, which fosters the emergence of a wide variety of human services nonprofits, highlighting their vital contributions. The researcher has chosen to focus on human services nonprofits because of their familiarity with this sector and the considerable social and civic importance these organizations hold.

Sampling Strategy

This study employed a combined convenience and purposive sampling strategy to recruit participants from human services nonprofit organizations in the Chicago area. Convenience sampling refers to the selection of participants based on their accessibility and proximity to the researcher, often used when the researcher has pre-existing relationships or direct access to the population of interest (Golzar et al., 2022). In this case, the researcher had previously worked for several years within the Chicago nonprofit sector and maintained professional connections with a range of organizational leaders. This insider status facilitated initial access to potential participants and helped establish trust and credibility, both essential for qualitative research on sensitive topics such as burnout and organizational leadership.

To ensure variation and relevance to the study's objectives, purposive sampling was used alongside convenience sampling to select nonprofit leaders who represented a range of organizational missions, service populations, and leadership structures. The purposive sampling approach allowed the researcher to deliberately target individuals with specific knowledge and experience relevant to the research questions—namely, those in leadership roles within human services nonprofits who are responsible for managing staff and shaping organizational culture. The goal was not to produce a statistically representative sample, but rather to ensure depth and diversity in the perspectives gathered regarding leadership strategies and approaches to mitigating employee burnout. By combining these two sampling strategies, the study was able to

recruit a rich and diverse group of nonprofit leaders who were well-positioned to provide meaningful insights into the role of servant leadership in addressing burnout within resource-constrained, mission-driven organizations.

Sample

The sample consisted of five leaders who were employed at nonprofit organizations based in Illinois at the time of the study. In addition to their existing social connections with the researcher, participants were selected based on their availability and their capacity to represent the diversity within Chicago's human services sector. The leaders surveyed came from a mix of large and small organizations, primarily focused on providing social services, case management, and after-school programming to low-income individuals in the city. These participants offered in-depth insights into the challenges faced by their respective organizations. They represented a range of missions, utilized various sources of labor, targeted different types of social inequities, and engaged with a diverse array of beneficiaries, contributing to a comprehensive understanding of the current landscape of social services within the nonprofit sector. The five-participant sample size was deemed adequate and aligns with Yin's (2018) recommendation for achieving sufficient data saturation in qualitative research.

Instruments

This study employed interviews as the primary method to identify and assess the burnout mitigation practices utilized by participants in their nonprofit organizations. The interview protocol comprised questions designed to explore both the professional and organizational backgrounds that shaped each participant's perspective, thereby providing relevant context. The researcher subsequently posed inquiries centered on the prevalence of burnout within the individual's organizational setting, the underlying causes of this burnout, and the strategies they

implemented to mitigate burnout among their employees. In crafting these questions, the researcher referenced various scholarly texts on servant leadership to develop a comprehensive understanding of what servant leadership entailed in the context of human services nonprofits. In alignment with the work of Sturm (2008), Greenleaf (2007), and Spears (2012), particular emphasis was placed on key constructs such as respect, collaboration, recognition of followers' achievements, empathy, and intrinsic humanism. The interview protocol consisted of 10 open-ended questions, which were developed in close collaboration between the researcher and their committee to ensure that the questions effectively addressed the study's stated objectives. The interview questions were pretested with practitioners from the field to ensure reliability. The interview protocol is included in Appendix A.

Data Collection Methods

Data collection began by identifying human service nonprofits in Chicago. This was done using official public websites and publicly available databases to gather contact information. An email invitation was sent to these organizations, addressed to executive-level staff. The email outlined the purpose of the study, the inclusion criteria, and the potential benefits of participation. It also included a detailed description of the study and instructions on how to express interest in participating. Follow-up emails or phone calls were made to ensure clarity and encourage responses. The message briefly explained the aims of the study, how the participants' information was obtained, the risks associated with the study, and provided contact information for any questions. If the researcher did not receive a response from a potential participant, or if a potential participant indicated they were not interested in participating, the researcher selected another organization of a similar size that had not been previously contacted, using the same random number generator approach.

After receiving the necessary permissions, the researcher contacted each participant to schedule a 45-60 minute interview via Zoom. Zoom was chosen for its high accessibility, reliability, and built-in recording feature, which was useful for creating interview transcripts (Gray et al., 2020). Before starting each interview on Zoom, the researcher re-explained the study's purpose, the risks and benefits of participation, how data would be collected and anonymized, and informed participants that they could opt to terminate the interview at any time. Participants provided their verbal consent during the Zoom call before the interview protocol began. Interviews were recorded using Zoom's built-in recorder. After all interviews were completed, the researcher transcribed each one into Microsoft Word and sent the transcripts back to the participants for member checking (Candela, 2019). During member checking, participants reviewed their interview responses to confirm that their experiences, perceptions, and feelings were accurately represented. They also had the opportunity to substantiate or correct their responses if they felt it was necessary. Data saturation was reached after five participants, eliminating the necessity of further interviews.

Data Analysis

Thematic analysis was used as the primary method for data analysis, following the six-phase approach outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006): (1) familiarization with the data, (2) generation of initial codes, (3) development of candidate themes, (4) review and refinement of themes, (5) definition and naming of final themes, and (6) synthesis and reporting of findings. Themes were iteratively refined by comparing document types and timeframes to ensure consistency and depth, in line with the chunking and coding process described by Miles et al. (2019). The researcher utilized digitized versions of the interview transcripts to analyze the interview data. Initially, the researcher reviewed all collected data multiple times to gain a

holistic understanding of what the interviews revealed. Subsequently, the researcher identified specific points where different ideas emerged. Recurrent points within the interviews were indicated and organized into various categories. These categories were then compiled into codes, which serve as brief summaries of the major themes present throughout the interview data. These codes were subsequently used to create the themes that guided the study's analysis.

Reliability and Validity

In qualitative research, reliability refers to the extent to which a tool could produce consistent results over time, while validity refers to how well a tool collects the type of data it claims to gather (Golafshani, 2003). According to Golafshani (2003), ensuring a high level of validity in a qualitative study also leads to a high level of reliability, as the responses are guided by the research tool. To ensure validity, the researcher closely collaborated with faculty members from Governors State University who specialized in nonprofit leadership. This collaboration helped ensure that the questions included in the interview protocol aligned with the study's aims.

To establish the credibility and trustworthiness of the findings, an audit trail was maintained throughout the process, documenting coding decisions, theme development, and interpretive memos. Additionally, the researcher conducted revision sessions with members of the dissertation committee to validate interpretations and minimize potential researcher bias. Reflexivity was practiced acknowledging the researcher's positionality and assumptions regarding nonprofit effectiveness and board performance. To ensure the reliability of the study's results, preliminary findings were communicated to participants using a member-checking strategy, as suggested in the literature (Candela, 2019). This approach verified that all responses were relevant and appropriate for the study.

Researcher Role

The researcher brought to this study over a decade of professional experience in the nonprofit sector, specifically within human services organizations in the Chicago area. This extensive background provided the researcher with deep contextual knowledge of the field and access to a broad network of nonprofit leaders, which was instrumental in participant recruitment. Leveraging these established professional relationships facilitated trust and openness during the data collection process, particularly when addressing sensitive topics such as leadership practices and employee burnout.

In conducting the study, the researcher assumed the role of an external observer with academic expertise in nonprofit management, public administration, and organizational behavior. This scholarly foundation informed the researcher's analytical approach and interpretive lens, particularly in applying servant leadership theory to understand organizational responses to burnout. While the researcher's proximity to the field enriched the study with insider insights, it also introduced the potential for bias in data interpretation. To mitigate this risk, the researcher employed strategies to enhance the credibility and trustworthiness of the study. These included triangulating findings with existing literature, maintaining a reflexive stance throughout the research process, and engaging in peer debriefing with dissertation committee members. Committee members provided critical feedback and reviewed the researcher's interpretations in relation to the interview data, ensuring that conclusions were grounded in the evidence rather than shaped by prior professional experiences. Through these practices, the researcher maintained analytic rigor while drawing upon their professional expertise to enhance the depth and relevance of the study.

Ethical Considerations

This study was reviewed by the Governors State University Institutional Review Board and received an exempt decision (IRB-FY2025-64). The ethical considerations for this study primarily involved the professional reputations of the participants and their respective organizations. Although leaders of human services-oriented nonprofit organizations may not have personally practiced servant leadership, they typically preferred that their organization's image—and their own professional image—aligned with the humanistic ideals of servant leadership. Furthermore, human services nonprofits could have faced negative perceptions if they disclosed data about their organizational functioning that indicated potential issues with long-term viability, such as high turnover rates. Consequently, it was critically important to maintain the anonymity of all participants and their organizations. To ensure that no participants could be identified, each was assigned a unique anonymized name (e.g., Participant A, Participant B), and discussions regarding organizations referred to them within categorical ranges (e.g., size of staff, size of beneficiary base, category). All participants were informed of the potential risks and benefits of participation in the study, allowing them to make an informed decision.

To minimize risks and ensure ethical compliance throughout the study, several procedures were implemented. Before interviews began, the participants were provided with a clear and detailed explanation of the study's purpose, risks, and benefits during the recruitment process to help them make an informed decision about their participation. The researcher verbally confirmed that the participant understood the study and consented to proceed. Informed consent clearly outlined the study's procedures to ensure participants feel comfortable and ensure that participant privacy is protected throughout the research process.

During the interview, participants were reminded that their involvement was entirely voluntary. They had the option to skip any questions or withdraw from the study at any time without facing any consequences. If the participants agreed, the interview was audio-recorded to facilitate accurate transcription and analysis. All recordings and transcripts were securely stored on password-protected devices, and any identifying information was anonymized to maintain confidentiality. At the conclusion of the interview, participants were thanked for their time and contributions. They were also reminded of their right to withdraw their data within a specified timeframe and received the researcher's contact information for any follow-up questions or concerns. Data will be kept securely stored for three years after the conclusion of the study, and access will be restricted to the researcher.

CHAPTER IV: RESULTS

This chapter presents the findings of a qualitative study that explored how nonprofit leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout through the lens of servant leadership. The purpose of the research was to determine whether and how servant leadership practices can mitigate or prevent burnout in nonprofit settings. Data was gathered through semi-structured interviews with four nonprofit leaders from diverse organizations, all of whom are actively involved in managing frontline staff. The interviews were transcribed and thematically analyzed using servant leadership theory as a guiding framework. The goal was to uncover patterns in leadership behavior, organizational support systems, and employee well-being. The following section describes the data coding method and participants' characteristics. The themes that emerged from the interviews are presented next and are supported by excerpts from the interviews to ground the analysis in the voices of the participants. The chapter concludes by summarizing the interview results and introducing the next steps of the research.

Data Collection

The study participants were selected using the convenience sampling approach, drawing on their existing connections within the Chicago area nonprofit sphere to find interview subjects. The researcher, who has been actively involved in Chicago-area nonprofit spheres for a long time, directly asked individuals they knew to be human services nonprofit leaders to participate in a study concerning nonprofit burnout. These connections had been forged through formal networking events, work connections, and school connections. Each participant was given a brief explanation of the study, what the researcher sought to achieve through the study, possible risks of participating in the study, and how the study may be used to improve the work of nonprofits operating in the Chicagoland area.

Interviews took place through the videoconferencing application Zoom between 10 March and April 25, 2025. Videoconferencing was used as the primary source of data collection in this study because it eliminated the need for travel on the part of all parties and because Zoom's built-in recording features allowed interview transcripts to be easily created. Prior to conducting data collection, the researcher gained the approval of the Governors State University IRB. Prior to each interview, participants gave informed consent to participate in the study. Before beginning the interview, the researcher read a description of the study, its intentions, the risks associated with participation, the potential benefits of participation, and the terms of participation. Participants were informed that, if at any time they wanted to cease their participation in the study, they were allowed to do so.

Analytical Approach

To analyze the qualitative interview data, a thematic coding process was employed to identify patterns and concepts related to servant leadership practices and employee burnout in nonprofit organizations. The coding process was guided by both the research questions and the theoretical framework grounded in servant leadership theory (Greenleaf, 2007; Eva et al., 2019). The analysis followed an iterative and inductive-deductive approach. First, interview transcripts were read in their entirety to gain familiarity with the data and to allow for initial reflection on emerging ideas. A preliminary set of codes was then developed based on the literature review, particularly the core elements of servant leadership practices (e.g., empathy, listening, commitment to growth, community building) and employee burnout (e.g., burnout symptoms and levels, burnout causes, and burnout's effect).

Next, a coding matrix was developed in Microsoft Excel to facilitate systematic data analysis. Each row in the matrix corresponded to a thematic code, while the testimonies of the

participants were included in the columns. The matrix allowed for the organization of coded segments by theme and sub-themes and included supporting verbatim quotes to ensure transparency and traceability. During coding, data segments were examined and categorized under appropriate themes and subthemes, while also noting the context and frequency of references. New codes were added when participants introduced insights that were not anticipated during the initial code development, allowing for emergent coding.

The Excel matrix also enabled comparative analysis across cases, helping to identify recurring patterns, outliers, and thematic relationships. For example, codes under the broader theme of "Servant Leadership Practices" were analyzed in relation to the reported presence or absence of burnout to examine whether specific leadership behaviors were perceived as mitigating factors. Likewise, barriers to implementing burnout-reduction strategies were cross-tabulated with organizational size and role of the respondent to surface potential organizational constraints. The themes that emerged from the interviews are presented below:

1. Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem
2. Servant Leadership Behaviors
3. Organizational Practices to Mitigate Burnout
4. Barriers to Burnout Mitigation

Each theme includes a set of sub-themes that offer deeper insight into the strategies leaders use to recognize, prevent, and respond to employee burnout (The description of sub-themes is provided in Appendix B).

To enhance the credibility and dependability of the coding process, the initial set of codes and emerging themes were reviewed by members of the capstone committee. After the primary researcher developed the initial coding matrix in Excel, committee members were invited to

review a sample of coded transcripts along with the corresponding coding structure. Their feedback was used to refine code definitions, ensure clarity and consistency, and confirm alignment with the study's conceptual framework. This collaborative validation process served as a form of peer debriefing, helping to mitigate potential researcher bias and strengthen the analytic rigor of the study. Committee members confirmed that the codes accurately reflected participant responses and supported the study's aim to explore the relationship between servant leadership practices and employee burnout in nonprofit organizations.

Participant Description

The participants represented a range of leadership experiences and nonprofit settings that varied widely in terms of mission and size (Table 1). These diverse perspectives are reflected in the study findings on how burnout manifests in the workplace and what leadership strategies are employed to mitigate and respond to this issue.

Table 1

Contexts for Participants

Participant	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5
Type of Organization	K-12 arts-based afterschool activity	Case management for urban males	Mentorship organization for Black and Brown girls and young women	Small case management organization	Community social services organization
Size of Beneficiary Base	Not given	Est. 4500-6000	Not given	~50 high-need cases	Not given
Size of Labor Base	300 volunteers	~300 employees	Four permanent employees, volunteer base (no number given)	10-15 employees	~100 employees

Participant 1 ran a nonprofit organization that held arts-based after-school activities for K-12 children in urban schools, with roughly 300 volunteers constituting the primary source of labor. Participant 2 ran a large nonprofit organization consisting of roughly 300 employees providing clinical case management support to urban males, with each case manager attending to roughly 15-20 individuals. Participant 3 ran a mentorship organization aimed at Black and Brown girls and young women in underprivileged communities, with four permanent employees and a small collection of affiliated contractors. Participant 4 ran a small nonprofit with 10-15 employees that managed roughly 50 cases of high-need individuals located in an urban area. Participant 5 ran an organization with roughly 100 employees that empowered vulnerable populations through providing direct mental health, educational, and workforce-related support.

Results

The thematic analysis of interviews with nonprofit leaders revealed the relationship between leadership practices and employee burnout, highlighting-four key themes (see Table 2). The first theme, Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem, shows how leaders recognize burnout's symptoms, such as emotional exhaustion and declining performance, and causes, as well as its broader impact on organizational missions. The second theme, Servant Leadership Behaviors, emerged as a central focus of the study. Leaders described a range of practices rooted in servant leadership theory, including stewardship, empathy, support for employee growth, and the intentional inclusion of staff voices in decision-making. Organizational Practices, the third theme, presents concrete interventions to address and mitigate burnout among employees, along with wellness programs and work-life balance policies, which support employee well-being and reflect a broader organizational commitment to servant leadership values. The fourth theme,

Barriers to Burnout Mitigation, addresses challenges such as resource constraints and cultural resistance to change that hinder burnout reduction efforts.

Table 2

Thematic Frequency Chart

Main Themes	Sub-themes	Participants Who Shared	Occurrence Number
Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem	Burnout symptoms	Participants 3, 4, 5	3 out of 5
	Burnout Impact	Participants 3, 4, 5	3 out of 5
	Burnout causes	All	5 out of 5
Servant Leadership Behaviors	Stewardship	Participants 2, 3, 4, 5	4 out of 5
	Empathy	All	5 out of 5
	Employee Inclusion & Growth	Participants 1, 3, 4	3 out of 5
Organizational Practices	Concrete Interventions	Participants 2, 4, 5	3 out of 5
	Work-Life Balance	Participants 2, 3, 4	3 out of 5
	Wellness & Healing	All	5 out of 5
Barriers to Burnout Mitigation	Resource Constraints	Participants 2, 3, 4, 5	4 out of 5
	Cultural Barriers	Participants 2, 3, 4, 5	4 out of 5
	Volunteer vs. Staff Differences	Participant 1, 3	2 out of 5

The following sections explore each theme in detail, using direct quotes from participants to illustrate how servant leadership principles are enacted and the impact they have on employee well-being.

Theme 1: Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem

Research suggests that the influence of the neoliberal economy and perpetual divestment in social services has created an untenable situation for many human service nonprofit workers,

who have been expected to perform more difficult and emotionally taxing work for less money (Alexander & Fernandez, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024). The physical and psychological exhaustion that these employees face as a result of the volume and nature of their work creates circumstances where burnout is common (Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Shi et al., 2020). Each participant indicated an awareness of the problem of burnout within human services nonprofits. Four sub-themes were identified within this theme: Burnout symptoms and levels; impact on organizational mission; monitoring employee well-being; and burnout causes in their organization. Table 3 includes testimonials for theme 3.

Table 3

Testimonial Examples for Theme 1: Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem

Subtheme	Description	Testimonial
Burnout Symptoms and Levels	Leaders' Awareness of physical and emotional indicators such as emotional exhaustion, reduced productivity, disengagement, and cynicism.	“They didn’t say it directly, but I could hear it... they’re overwhelmed.” - P3
Impact on Organizational Mission	Recognition that burnout affects the organization’s capacity to deliver quality services, retain staff, and achieve mission-driven outcomes.	“When staff are stretched too thin or emotionally fatigued, it impacts client outcomes and staff morale. That's why we're being proactive.” - P5
Burnout Causes in Their Organizations	Leaders' insight into both structural and emotional sources of burnout, such as excessive workloads, multitasking, and staffing shortages inherent in nonprofit work, that contribute to burnout or/vicarious trauma resulting from continuous exposure to clients’ distressing life experiences.	“They're not, you know, letting us know, using the resources that's available for them being more private with some burnt out issues and maybe just leaving the organization rather than just talking about it and using those available resources.” - P1

Burnout Symptoms and Levels

All respondents demonstrated awareness of physical and emotional indicators of burnout, such as emotional exhaustion, reduced productivity, disengagement, and cynicism among staff. They described how burnout often manifests through emotional exhaustion, reduced productivity, and a visible decline in employee well-being. As Participant 2 explained, "He [the employee] confessed to me that he was experiencing it [...] and wasn't on his A game." Leaders also noted behavioral cues such as disengagement or avoidance. Participant 2 indicated that there was a tendency among employees towards burnout, and attributed this to both a lack of opportunity to adequately recuperate in between appointments within different human services nonprofit positions and the fear that employment gaps may have negative implications for caseworkers' ranks within their field. Participant 5 indicated that some of their staff was at risk of burnout, indicating that the field of nonprofit human services was, "incredibly rewarding but also emotionally demanding."

Impact on Organizational Mission

All participants recognized that burnout affects the organization's capacity to deliver quality services, retain staff, and achieve mission-driven outcomes. Several leaders emphasized that staff well-being is critical for organizational success, and staff who felt supported were more likely to remain committed and perform effectively. Participant 5 noted, "When staff are stretched too thin or emotionally fatigued, it impacts client outcomes." Participant 3, whose organization only contains a handful of permanent employees with whom the participant interacts daily, discussed noticing a gradual decrease in energy and increase in stress that their employees would not openly discuss having. Participant 3 attributed this to their firm commitment to the organization's mission, and a perception that they could not "come to

[Participant 3] to say, like, ‘Man, I need a break,’ or ‘I’m tired’ or ‘I’m burnt out. They just say ‘I’m good and I’m okay’ and just continue to do the work.” Participant 4 detailed a story of an individual rendered unable to properly fulfill the demands of their role due to the incredible emotional impact of one particular case, demonstrating how, in some cases, organizational impact can be derailed by the outsized demands of one case.

Burnout Causes

Most of the participants highlighted the fact that non-profit work is connected with burnout. A common theme was the role of excessive workloads and multitasking. Participants 2 described this as "In nonprofit work, you’re like an octopus... managing seven other things." Another key contributor was vicarious trauma, particularly among staff working with marginalized populations. Participants 2, 3, and 4, all of whom work with populations that have experienced substantial exposure to traumatic circumstances, acknowledged the significant emotional and professional burdens that accompany human services nonprofit work. Participant 1’s nonprofit was activity-based and did not carry the same types of risk of traumatic exposure, the same obligation to continue working on the part of volunteers, and the same expendable demand on volunteers’ time. Participant 4 indicated that while they did not believe their employees to be burned out at the time of the interview, they recognized that the potential always exists, saying, “Burnout in the nonprofits [often stems] from high emotional labor [...]. We work closely with individuals and families dealing with trauma, instabilities, and economic hardships. And that level of service requires sustained emotional presence.”

Participant 4 believed that it was more effective to frame employee burnout in terms of trauma exposure rather than burnout. This framing device demonstrates a profoundly humanistic positionality on the part of Participant 4, who understands the types of personal sacrifices that

their employees make are personally burdensome for them. This is an inversion of the model of self-sacrifice in Robichau et al.'s (2024) work, which conceives of human services work as providing a "psychic income" from the moral accumulation of good deeds that is ultimately of greater value to human service practitioners than other types of compensation. In other words, rather than viewing human services workers as forming an endlessly manipulable well of labor due to their personal moral commitments, Participant 4 recognizes that these types of demands place massive stress on their workers -- stress that demands to be legitimized in a nearly paramedical lens. This speaks to the recommendations of Clary and Rose (2022) and the findings of Gabriel and Aguinis (2021), both of which emphasize the importance of demonstrations of care for nonprofit employees on the part of management.

Theme 2: Servant Leadership Behaviors

Across all interviews, servant leadership principles consistently emerged as effective tools for reducing burnout. Servant leadership theory posits that effective leaders leverage their intimate understanding of followers' abilities, weaknesses, goals, and interests to drive motivation and organizational performance (De Clerck et al., 2021; Greenleaf, 2007; Langhof & Guldenberg, 2020). Leaders emphasized the need to be emotionally attuned to their staff, responsive to unspoken concerns, and intentional in building wellness-centered cultures. Four subthemes were identified: stewardship, empathy, and employee inclusion and growth

Stewardship

Stewardship can be defined as a sense of responsibility for the overall health of the organization and well-being of its people, beyond operational duties. The awareness of the leaders about the impact of burnout on organizational mission made them pay attention to employees' behavior to identify whether they are at risk of burnout. All participants indicated

that, in order to prevent burnout, it was necessary to continually pay attention to the personal well-being of their employees and affiliates. The responses highlighted the use of multiple monitoring tools to identify when personal or group-level challenges may be arising. Some leaders combine behavioral observation with informal discussions. Participants 3 and 4 both indicated that the relatively small sizes of their organizations allowed them to better monitor their staff members, both formally and informally. For example, Participant 3 has a small staff of four permanent employees, which allows the leader to have frequent formal and informal interactions with the employees and observe their behavior and expression on a regular basis. Participant 4, whose operation is significantly larger than Participant 3's, indicated more proactive and data-driven methods of monitoring employee burnout. Participant 4 said, "We use a mix of anonymous surveys, one-on-one conversations with leadership, and open-group debriefs, depending on the team's comfort level. Participant 5 indicated that their organization used a mixture of formal check-ins, wellness surveys, and open communication between staff and leadership to ensure a free exchange of ideas concerning wellness.

Empathy

Theorists of servant leadership have indicated that empathetic approaches to management, in which leaders actively seek to take the emotional perspectives of employees, are effective means of building morale and organizational strength (Divya & Suganthi, 2018; Spears, 2012). One participant indicated that empathy was a key means of ensuring high morale among employees. Participant 3 said,

> "[Employees] may not come to you and say, 'I'm tired,' or they don't want to let you down, or whatever it might be. But they're saying it in a way that you're probably not just catching, with this repeated overwhelming or exhaustion or whatever. So, really

> listen to that. And then have a conversation and meet with them to [say], 'Okay, how can I support you if you're feeling overwhelmed or tired or whatever it is?' Because they're not going to be their best selves."

In this instance, Participant 3's ability to intuit that their employees are facing some sort of distressing personal problem is, in part, determined by their ability to continually see that employee in the workplace. This speaks to the tenets of servant leadership style, as advocated by Eva et al. (2019) and Greenleaf (2007). Boone and Makhani's (2012) and Spears' (2008) findings on the importance of servant leaders' commitments to community-building, active listening, and healing are widely demonstrated in Participant 3's employee-centered approach. Similarly, Participant 3 demonstrates a high degree of direct support for their employees, mirroring the findings of Ciancio's (2021) relating to highly effective behaviors of human service leaders. In small teams that work with each other on a daily or near-daily basis, this type of intimate, personal check-in is feasible.

Employee Inclusion and Growth

For participants, employee growth is not strictly defined in terms of reportable career-based skills. Participant 3 indicated that one skill that they seek to advance within their team is paying attention to other team members' emotional states and reporting on those challenges in a formal context. Participant 3 discussed how the multifaceted, highly demanding nature of a leadership position can occasionally create gaps in understanding concerning the real state of the group, and how explicitly teaching skills concerning this type of reporting may help improve both team functioning and individual well-being.

Participant 4 also indicated that they train leadership candidates to recognize signs of burnout, echoing the intentions of Participant 3 and demonstrating a tangible investment in new

leaders. Participant 2 discussed their perception of the importance of investing in successful people, discussing the idea that people's circumstances determine how they use their talents, and that it is important to recognize those talents to ensure they are used constructively.

Participants indicated that inclusive and supportive practices were important means of ensuring that individual needs were adequately met. Participant 4 indicated that creating intentional subgroupings of employees was necessary to ensure the type of individualized support consistent with servant leadership could be realized. Participant 4 said, "For newer or high-stress initiatives, we may increase [the frequency of monthly wellness checks] to weekly. We also train [our team leads] to recognize early signs of burnout, like withdrawal, irritability, or drops and performance [...] so they can step in before things escalate." The explicit invocation of "team leads" here suggests that Participant 4's organization breaks their groupings up in a manner that encourages more personal connections between leaders and employees, mirroring both Participant 3's model of direct service and the recommendations of Ciancio (2021) regarding demonstrations of employee commitment. Growth opportunities also extended outside of the work world. Participant 2 proposed the provision of personal finance classes for employees, to see if a greater understanding of how to manage one's own money may translate into a reduced stress level for employees worried about their ability to weather the economic uncertainty faced by the sector. Participant 2 also proposed that a self-care stipend may be positive for employees. See Table 4 for testimonial examples for Theme 2.

Table 4

Testimonial Examples for Theme 2: Servant Leadership Behaviors

Subtheme	Description	Testimonial
Empathy	Leaders' ability to understand and validate employees' emotional states and personal challenges. Active attentiveness to employee concerns, both spoken and unspoken, and willingness to adapt based on feedback.	"The goal is to create space for honesty without fear and to make sure nobody feels invisible or overwhelmed and silenced." - P4
Employee Inclusion and Growth	Commitment to nurturing staff through professional development, mentoring, recognition, and capacity building. Encouraging participation of staff in organizational decisions and valuing their input as co-creators of solutions.	"We all get together and we sit and talk. We go over different cases and things that we may have and different issues and problems that they have. I think that strengthens the team. And we're all able to -- if there's something that they're dealing with we give them strategies to deal with what they're dealing with to help them out. And I think that helps us as a team come together more." - P3
Stewardship	A sense of responsibility for the overall health of the organization and well-being of its people, beyond operational duties. Intentional efforts to monitor employee Well-being to detect burnout, including formal assessments (e.g., surveys), informal feedback, and behavioral observation.	"And he confessed to me. That he wasn't on his A game. You know, and when the conversation concluded. About 15 minutes later, I got an email from them saying that he needs to step down to focus on his health and things like that." - P2

Theme 3: Organizational Practices to Mitigate Burnout

Participants indicated that whole-organization practices could be leveraged to mitigate burnout through a combination of active organizational interventions, monitoring practices, and

cultural improvements. These practices demonstrate a focus on employee care consistent with Greenleaf's (2007) model of servant leadership, particularly in their cultivation of empathy. Three sub-themes were identified: concrete interventions, promoting work-life balance, and wellness practices.

Concrete Interventions

Concrete interventions are defined as responses to burnout that respond to the individual needs of employees, including flexible schedules, workload adjustments, and self-care support (Eva et al., 2019). Participant 4 indicated an experience in which an employee's commitment to saving a family who were facing housing insecurity completely consumed their life, and how this employee was taken off the assignment out of concern for their well-being. This demonstrates a healthy understanding of the limitations of the work, and a desire to ensure that strong-willed employees with deeply-held commitments to service do not burn out. Participant 4 indicated that actively identifying struggles that employees faced and giving them the resources necessary to heal from potential traumatic exposure or overwork was a necessary practice. Participant 4 indicated that their organization puts out a monthly employee wellness survey that poses questions like "How are you feeling emotionally and mentally? What's been weighing on you lately? Is there any support need that you're not getting?" The combination of these different forms of questioning allows for a more holistic image of the challenges facing organizational employees to arise.

Participant 4 explicitly indicated the importance of building an organizational culture that emphasizes the importance of foregrounding health concerns. Participant 4 also indicated that, in cases where employee burnout is identified, leaders continually follow up with employees to monitor their ongoing recovery process. These overlapping vectors for wellness checks and this

apparent organizational emphasis on understanding the holistic experiences of employees demonstrate the cultivation of openness, mutual consideration, and teamwork, in line with Greenleaf's (2007) vision of servant leadership and De Clerck et al.'s (2021) prioritization of the maintenance of clear structure as a part of servitude. The organization's active anticipation of burnout as a near-inevitability demonstrates a profound understanding of the nature of the work, a deep empathy for the personal demands placed on employees, and a systemic approach to employee retention. Participant 5 indicated the implementation of "mental health days, flexible scheduling, and [...] access to counseling and EAP services" as standard practices at their organization. Participant 5 also indicated regularly checking in with department heads in the interest of making workloads more manageable.

Promoting Work-Life Balance

Leaders who seek to protect personal time, encourage regular breaks, protect on-the-clock employee time, and support sustainable workloads can be said to promote work-life balance (Robichau et al., 2024). Research suggests that human services nonprofit leaders who do not prescribe self-sacrificial behaviors and instead promote work-life balance improve employee confidence, employee satisfaction, and ultimately, turnover intentions (De Clerck et al., 2021; Kuenzi et al., 2021; Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021).

All participants indicated that direct care of some kind was administered to employees by organizational leaders. One means of care provision is protecting employees' time. Palumbo et al. (2022) and Robichau et al. (2024) indicated that time-related limitations can contribute substantially to burnout intention, owing to the fact that many tasks related to human services nonprofit work demand quick turnarounds and are often attached to emotionally-loaded potential outcomes.

Participant 3 indicated that they placed particular limitations on meeting times, durations of meetings, and reasons for meetings in the interest of self-delegation. Meetings were scheduled in half-hour increments rather than hour increments in order to maximize time efficiency and ensure that each employee's calendar contained as much open time as possible. Participant 3 indicated that they slated particular Fridays as "No Meeting Fridays," in which each permanent employee was solely tasked with completing whatever task they may need to catch up on, and were given free reign to determine what those tasks might be. Participant 3 also placed an emphasis on not conducting any work in-person that could be done digitally. Here, Participant 3 is demonstrating a desire to provide employees with as much autonomy in their work as possible, as advised by Gabriel and Aguinis (2021).

Wellness Practices

Programs that build team cohesion -- such as formalized forms of peer support, resilience workshops, and retreats -- and emotional resilience -- such as wellness resources and stress recovery opportunities -- can be considered wellness practices (McClure & Moore, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024). Some participants indicated that their organizations practiced approaches to self-care that sought to address the struggles of employees on an individual level. While all participants indicated that self-care was an important aspect of addressing the question of burnout, there were different emphases placed on self-care, generally tied to the size of the organization. Participant 2, whose organization was significantly larger than those of the other participants, repeatedly emphasized the importance of self-care in their interview, creating a clear division of responsibilities between employees and the organization. Participant 2 indicated that self-advocacy was an important skill that was vital for success in the world of human services nonprofits, but that a culture of "playing through the pain" was unsustainable.

Participant 2 indicated that their organization hosted retreats for employees that foregrounded the importance of self-care. Participant 2 discussed the importance of the practice of maintaining a detailed schedule, indicating that workers must respect their own work-life balance needs. Smaller nonprofits' leaders also placed an emphasis on the importance of self-care, but this emphasis was tempered by a higher degree of attentiveness and a greater focus on the importance of leadership-employee communication, as practiced by Participants 3 and 4.

Participant 4 indicated that they offered employees tools to self-assess their levels of burnout or to speak with a supervisor in the case that they understood themselves as experiencing burnout. This was characterized as a means through which nonprofit leaders could start conversations with employees concerning their experiences and needs. Participant 1 indicated that self-advocacy was the key means through which volunteers could improve their work conditions -- principally through indicating that they have run into challenges working with a particular group or beneficiaries of a particular age range -- but organizational relationships with volunteers and employees are not the same.

Participant 3 indicated that developing an organizational culture where self-care is prioritized was important for addressing burnout, but also repeatedly indicated throughout the interview that, because of the small size of their team, they were able to actively monitor the work experiences of their employees and respond to them. Participant 3 also discussed "No Meeting Fridays" and emphasized the importance of limiting the time and scope of meetings in order to maximize employees' free time. This was done with the intention of limiting pressure for employees, and to ensure that all independent work is taken care of at a steady pace so it does not become overwhelming. See Table 5 for testimonial examples for Theme 3.

Table 5

Testimonial Examples for Theme 3: Organizational Practices

Subtheme	Description	Testimonial
Concrete Interventions	Personalized burnout responses, such as flexible schedules, workload adjustments, and self-care support.	"So the organization has a self-care massage. They were like a massage week or something that the organization covers. They cover it I believe, quarterly, you know, and they'll reimburse you for that." - P4
Work-Life Balance	Organizational efforts that protect personal time, encourage time off and regular breaks, support sustainable workloads, and protect employee time.	"Now, what I've implemented at the organization is that every quarter, before we transition into a new quarter, we're doing a four-day sabbatical. So we can just be refreshed, rejuvenated, so we can go into the next quarter with just the right mindset." - P3
Wellness and Healing	Programs that build emotional resilience and team cohesion, including retreats, peer support, and resilience workshops & training, and other wellness resources; available opportunities for recovery from stress or trauma through a supportive and restorative organizational culture.	"So I would say, like I say, our burnout is low to moderate. And when we come across someone that's having those problems, we have an open-door policy, so if's employee feels like they had a bad day or there's something that's, you know. We encourage them to open up to us. We can remove them or have them give them some time to cope. And we can go on with the mission, and our beneficiaries don't feel that." - P4

Theme 4. Barriers to Burnout Mitigation

All participants indicated significant barriers to the mitigation of burnout in the course of their interviews. The existing body of literature has suggested that problems with budgetary allocations, increases in organizational demands, short timelines, and challenging partnerships can all create circumstances that contribute to burnout's growth (Lubbadeh, 2020; Searing et al.,

2021; Shi et al., 2020). Three subthemes were identified as barriers to burnout mitigation: resource constraints, cultural barriers, and volunteer versus staff differences. See Table 6 for testimonial examples for Theme 4.

Table 6

Testimonial Examples for Theme 4: Barriers to Burnout Mitigation

Subtheme	Description	Testimonial
Resource Constraints	Limited financial, human, and time resources restrict the organization's ability to implement wellness strategies.	"It's also about systematic pressures that nonprofits face, like the underfunding, unrealistic expectations from funders. And the emotional toll of trying to solve generational problems with limited tools." - P4
Cultural Barriers	Organizational norms or practices that prevent employees from taking actions to disclose being stressed or burned out, a culture that nonprofit employees need to be strong to be able to help vulnerable others, or existing stigma about emotional stress or mental health issues.	"I know one organization they got unlimited PTO. You know what I'm saying? But I'm sure if we pull the data on that to see who are using it, I'm quite sure. Not too many. You know, maybe that one staff member who likes to go to Vegas once a week to gamble." - P2
Volunteer vs. Staff Differences	Specific challenges in managing burnout across different roles, particularly between paid staff and volunteers.	"I think it is the uncertainty of the uncertainty like… our facilitators, right? So at the beginning of the year, we had a facilitator who we thought was going to be ready to rock and roll to go manage all 12 of our sites. And she ended up saying, I can't do it. And so now it's like a program started. We are already in the swing of things. So we all have to come in and fill gaps." - P3

Resource Constraints

Human services nonprofits have limited financial, human, and time resources that limit their abilities to implement wellness strategies. Nonprofit organizations must constantly compete with each other for extremely limited resources from donors while simultaneously maintaining the capacity for rapid adjustment to support the changing needs of profoundly disadvantaged beneficiaries (Reichman, 2010; Shi et al., 2020).

Participant 5 succinctly stated, "Budget is always a concern in nonprofits. We can't always provide the highest salaries or benefits, which can increase stress." This can contribute to instability within the organization, where personal financial problems may impact employee performance, or where high-performing employees may feel pulled to better-paying jobs with larger nonprofits or in the private sector. Participant 3, who runs a mentorship-based nonprofit organization, discussed the instability inherent in reliance on public funding. In response to a follow-up question, in which the researcher asked, "I do want to bring up that you had spoken of [stressors] surrounding finances -- how do you manage that when it's out of your control?," Participant 3 indicated the importance of understanding the precarity involved in their work and the importance of intentionality in organizational scaling.

This demonstrates the cognizance of a greater existential risk to these types of organizations: changes in policy and governmental leadership can result in profound shifts in fortunes for many human services nonprofits. This is also a vector for stress within these organizations, as these changes can create a profound sense of anxiety in both leaders and employees. The experience of having to work with people living in highly volatile situations is stressful on its own, but it is compounded significantly by employees' own challenges with precarity. Participant 3's discussion also creates a new dimension of consideration for Participant

2's points in their response to Question 2 concerning the perceived importance of prestige among employees and the possibility of burnout persisting across organizational appointments. It is possible that burnout within human services nonprofits should not solely be viewed as a question of organizational culture and managerial practice, but a sector-wide problem that carries demands for all managers and workers.

Cultural Barriers

Cultural barriers are the norms or practices that prevent employees from obtaining the types of support necessary to limit burnout. Research indicates that cultures of self-sacrifice and the valorization of "grit" are common in human services nonprofits, often to the detriment of employees (Robichau et al., 2024; Searing et al., 2021). In some cases, though organizations did extend care-related services to employees, they were fairly limited in scope. Participant 2 discussed the provision of a quarterly massage to employees, but also shared doubts about the efficacy of this prescription of a particular approach to self-care. A self-care stipend offered to employees on a regular basis, Participant 2 said, would be a better means of improving employee morale and stamina. Though Participant 2 shared positive feelings concerning offering a greater degree of schedule-based flexibility for employees, they also indicated wariness of particular sweeping approaches to flexibility that appeared to be beyond what they perceived as the scope of feasibility -- or even sympathy. For example, Participant 2 discussed their skepticism over the provision of unlimited paid time off, an incentive they had heard was offered by another organization. Participant 2 said, "I know one organization, they got unlimited PTO. [...] I'm sure if we pull the data on that to see who is using it, I'm quite sure [it's] not too many. [...] Maybe that one staff member who likes to go to Vegas once a week to gamble." Though Participant 2 is essentially sympathetic to the idea that employees may need additional time off or types of

accommodations beyond the normal scope of organizational care, they do not view approaches like these as essentially plausible or desirable. This contrasts with Participant 4's approach to leveraging additional time off, which offers a greater degree of fluidity due to higher whole-organization buy-in.

On some level, this can be understood as a demonstration of the lasting inefficiencies that exist within the nonprofit space, and how well-funded organizations are able to compile significant reserves despite the inherent inefficiencies in their impersonal organizational design. On another level, this can be understood as an example of the fundamental disingenuity of an approach to employee care like this; as Participant 2 indicates, the promise of unlimited paid time off is only an approach organizations can even begin to pay lip service to because of the persistent understanding of human services nonprofit employees as driven by something tantamount to a need to serve. This is a representation of the patterns of manipulative behaviors on the parts of nonprofit leaders discussed in Robichau et al. (2024) and Clary and Rose (2022), under the ruse of uncharacteristic generosity. At the same time, this statement suggests a baseline wariness of organizations willing to cede significant amounts of resources to their employees on the part of Participant 2. Participant 2 replied, "We take on the role of wanting to service everybody and their family," which aptly recognizes the fundamental necessity of monitoring and aiding employees.

Volunteer vs. Staff Differences

Some participants indicated that burnout can manifest differently or influence organizational dynamics in different ways when sources of labor other than permanent staff experience it. Research has demonstrated that organizational discord can be just as counterproductive for volunteer labor as it can for paid labor (De Clerck et al., 2021).

Participants 1 and 3 both drew on their experiences with volunteers as a source of organizational labor. Participant 3 indicated that inadequate follow-through from facilitators creates substantial challenges for their permanent employees, on the same level of inadequate follow-through from contractors. Participant 3 stated that, in situations when facilitators were not able or willing to perform their volunteer duties, full-time employees were often tasked with taking their place, adding to a sense of frustration. Participant 1's nonprofit organization is principally driven by volunteer labor, and acts primarily as a means of coordinating the efforts of a wide variety of volunteers for arts-related activities -- generally, thought of as an enjoyable thing for volunteers to do rather than a task based in a sense of personal or civic duty. Participant 1's sole challenges were a result of a lack of follow-through with their volunteer base. These two accounts raise challenging questions concerning the importance of volunteer labor in human services nonprofit work, and the duty of human services nonprofit managers in addressing the challenges of volunteer workers.

Findings

The interviews revealed the nuanced and deeply human ways in which nonprofit leaders apply servant leadership principles to recognize, address, and prevent employee burnout. Across all five cases, leaders emphasized the importance of empathy, active listening, individualized support, and building a culture of trust and care. The information uncovered in Theme 1, "Leadership Awareness of the Burnout Problem" demonstrates that leaders generally understood that nonprofit work is emotionally demanding due to the high volume of beneficiary need and the emotionally taxing aspects of human service work. Leaders understood that the challenges facing their employees were formidable, and understood that if employees were not adequately supported, the potential consequences of the fallout could be profoundly damaging for

organizational mission. Participants indicated that the roots of burnout were systemic and sector wide, owing to pervasive social inequalities, overburdening of individual human services employees, limitations in government funds, and mismanagement in other organizations, among other causes.

Theme 2, “Servant Leadership Behaviors,” demonstrated that participants seek to demonstrate a great degree of individual consideration in their work with employees. While burnout was recognized as an inherent risk in emotionally demanding nonprofit work, participants demonstrated a strong commitment to supporting staff well-being through flexible time division practices, wellness initiatives, and open communication. Participants discussed attempts to maximize organizational transparency through actively listening to the needs of participants, advocate for employees experiencing burnout, and trusting employees with a great degree of personal autonomy. Participants indicated that employee wellbeing was a major consideration in their approaches to leadership, seeking to ensure that employees felt cared for and that employee voices were heard in their organizations.

Theme 3, “Organizational Practices,” explored the different practical strategies that participants used to support their employees. Despite facing constraints such as limited funding and staff capacity, leaders found creative and human-centered ways to care for their teams. Participants focused on implementing flexible approaches to time off, conducting regular mental health check-ins, bringing about cultural change that valorized help-seeking behaviors, ensuring that employees had access to self-care resources, and establishing healthy boundaries in terms of when and how work is done. Participants emphasized the importance of anticipating burnout, in the interest of both protecting individual employees and protecting the integrity of the

organization at large. These practices effectively reduced stress and turnover, while also significantly strengthening alignment with participants' organizational missions.

Though these findings demonstrate positive practices for human services nonprofit leaders, in Theme 4, "Barriers to Burnout Mitigation," several leaders acknowledged persistent challenges to these humanistic approaches and factors that continue to bring about burnout. Limitations in funding led to stressors relating to employee underpayment, the threat of employee turnover, role overload, and tensions between funders and nonprofits. Persistent stigma around expressing vulnerability -- generally linked to employee perception of the importance of organizational mission -- created significant barriers to communication that participants indicated contributed to burnout. Participants also discussed the challenges of working with volunteers as opposed to employees. Overall, these findings suggest that servant leadership can offer a sustainable framework for fostering resilience, improving retention, and maintaining organizational mission integrity.

Chapter Summary

This chapter presented the analysis of the interviews conducted with nonprofit leaders with the purpose of exploring how these leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout through the lens of servant leadership. The narratives provided by participants highlight that servant leadership offers a valuable framework for nonprofit leaders seeking to prevent or mitigate employee burnout. The findings underscore the importance of individualized support, intentional leadership, and values-driven decision-making in addressing burnout in nonprofit environments. The next chapter discusses these findings in relation to the broader literature and implications for nonprofit leadership development.

CHAPTER V: CONCLUSIONS AND ANALYSIS

The purpose of this study was to explore how nonprofit leaders perceive and respond to employee burnout through the lens of servant leadership, while accounting for the broader structural constraints that influence leadership behavior in the nonprofit sector. By drawing connections between the study's findings and the existing literature on servant leadership and burnout within nonprofit organizations, this chapter critically examines how leadership practices are shaped, enacted, and sometimes constrained by the systemic realities of the sector. The chapter is organized into four key sections. It begins with a discussion of the major themes that emerged from the semi-structured interviews, highlighting the ways in which nonprofit leaders conceptualize and address employee burnout. The next section outlines the study's implications for organizational practice and offers evidence-based recommendations for cultivating wellness-centered, servant-led leadership development. This is followed by a reflection on the study's methodological strengths and limitations, as well as suggestions for future research that can deepen our understanding of nonprofit leadership and well-being. The chapter concludes by articulating the study's contributions to theory and practice in the fields of nonprofit leadership, human resource management, and organizational development.

Analysis

The results of the interviews affirm that servant leadership provides an effective conceptual and practical framework for addressing burnout in nonprofit organizations. Across the cases, participants identified that empathy, individualized support, and proactive staff engagement were essential tools not only to reduce symptoms of burnout but also to build organizational resilience. This finding aligns with the body of literature that positions servant leadership as uniquely well-suited for human service settings, as it explicitly centers the well-

being and development of the follower—a leadership approach that has demonstrated positive effects on employee well-being, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment in emotionally demanding environments (Eva et al., 2019; van Dierendonck, 2011; Rivkin et al., 2014). In nonprofit work environments characterized by high emotional labor and constrained resources (Muse, 2018; Palumbo et al, 2022; Rendon, 2024), the relational and values-driven nature of servant leadership becomes especially valuable (McClure & Moore, 2021; Palumbo et al., 2022).

Participants' emphasis on emotional attunement, trauma-informed leadership, and creating wellness-centered organizational cultures supports the growing scholarly argument that burnout in nonprofit settings cannot be managed solely through individual resilience or traditional managerial oversight (Gabriel & Aguinis, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024). Rather, it requires intentional leadership practices rooted in care, trust, and mutual accountability (Robichau et al., 2024; Sewell et al., 2025). This leadership orientation not only fosters healthier organizational climates but also helps to sustain nonprofit workers who often face high emotional demands and moral pressures tied to their mission-driven work (Grandey et al., 2013).

Understanding Burnout in the Nonprofit Sector

This study contributes to a more nuanced understanding of burnout in the nonprofit sector by reinforcing and expanding existing scholarship that frames burnout not solely as an individual psychological condition, but as a structural and cultural phenomenon embedded in the daily work of nonprofit professionals. The findings confirm that burnout is closely linked to persistent resource constraints, emotionally intensive service delivery, and the expectations of moral commitment to the mission—factors that are well documented in previous studies (McClure & Moore, 2021; Palumbo et al., 2022; Sewell et al., 2025). What this study adds is a leadership-

centered narrative that articulates how burnout is perceived and managed by those tasked with supporting staff under these, often untenable, conditions.

Participants' reflections revealed that burnout frequently goes unspoken, in part due to the stigma surrounding vulnerability in nonprofit work environments. Staff may feel compelled to minimize their distress for fear of appearing uncommitted to the cause, a behavior consistent with what Robichau et al. (2024) describe as the "heroism narrative" in nonprofit culture. This culture of self-sacrifice, while rooted in meaningful service values, can perpetuate silent suffering and prevent timely interventions. The findings illustrate that leaders who recognize this dynamic and proactively create space for open dialogue about emotional well-being are better positioned to prevent burnout before it escalates.

The study extends the application of servant leadership theory by demonstrating that its core principles—empathy, stewardship, listening, and commitment to employee development—can serve as protective factors against burnout. Prior research has shown that servant leadership improves job satisfaction, psychological health, and organizational commitment (Eva et al., 2019; Rivkin et al., 2014; van Dierendonck, 2011). This study advances those insights by illustrating how nonprofit leaders specifically use servant leadership to recognize emotional distress, tailor support to individual needs, and construct workplace cultures that prioritize care over performance metrics. For instance, Participant 3's ability to sense unspoken signs of exhaustion and respond empathetically reflects Greenleaf's foundational call for leaders to serve first and lead second (Sen Sendjaya et al., 2002). These behaviors align with evidence that emotionally intelligent and ethical leadership fosters trust and well-being in emotionally demanding work environments (Chughtai, 2018; Chughtai et al., 2015).

Organizational size and capacity emerged as important contextual variables. Leaders from smaller nonprofits were able to engage in frequent, informal wellness check-ins due to flatter hierarchies and close-knit teams. By contrast, larger organizations implemented structured practices such as monthly wellness surveys, mental health days, or retreat programming. While these approaches differed in formality, both reflected intentional strategies to translate servant leadership values into operational practice. This supports and expands findings from Palumbo et al. (2022), who emphasize that burnout interventions must be adapted to organizational capacity, and from Darul Wiyono et al. (2024), who demonstrate that servant leadership has a significant impact on workplace culture and burnout reduction when strategically embedded.

Importantly, the study brings to the forefront the persistent tension between idealism and sustainability in nonprofit work. Leaders acknowledged that their staff often experience burnout due to systemic challenges such as unstable funding, shifting government policies, and the unpredictability of donor priorities. These findings echo concerns raised by Sharp Eizinger and Roof (2025), who describe widespread stress and workforce instability across the nonprofit sector. By illustrating how leaders recognize and attempt to navigate this contradiction, the study adds a valuable dimension to ongoing conversations about structural reform and leadership responsibility.

The findings also begin to address an underdeveloped area in the literature: the impact of burnout on volunteers. While most burnout research focuses on paid staff, this study highlights how the burden placed on volunteers, particularly in smaller organizations, can indirectly intensify burnout for full-time staff who must absorb their unfulfilled responsibilities. This observation expands on insights from McClure and Moore (2021), who call for trauma-informed leadership that encompasses all members of the nonprofit workforce.

Burnout as a Systemic Issue

One of the most striking findings was participants' unanimous recognition that burnout is not simply a result of individual fragility or poor time management but stems from sector-wide challenges. Participants linked burnout to broader structural conditions, including excessive workloads, emotionally demanding service delivery, and chronic underfunding—circumstances that are pervasive across the human services sector (McClure & Moore, 2021; Palumb et al., 2022). These insights challenge simplistic understandings of burnout as an individual's failure to cope, instead framing it as an occupational hazard inherent in nonprofit work. This interpretation is consistent with existing literature on mission-driven fields, which highlights how emotional labor, precarious funding, and chronic overextension produce workplace conditions that are ripe for psychological exhaustion (Grandey et al., 2013; Maslach et al., 2001). These include chronic underfunding, excessive caseloads, exposure to client trauma, and the precariousness of nonprofit employment—challenges well-documented in both empirical research and practitioner accounts (McClure & Moore, 2021; Palumbo et al., 2022; Sewell et al., 2025).

Interviewees described these pressures as endemic to the human services sector, and not isolated to any one organization. This perception marks a critical shift in the understanding of burnout. Rather than viewing it as a failure of the individual or of organizational leadership alone, participants framed burnout as a predictable outcome of systemic dysfunction. Their accounts support the growing discourse on occupational trauma and "moral distress" in nonprofit work, especially where employees are unable to meet the needs of clients due to external constraints (Sewell et al., 2025). Moreover, the emphasis placed on vicarious trauma by several participants adds nuance to the discussion, indicating that burnout in nonprofit settings is not

merely about workload but about prolonged exposure to suffering without adequate recovery mechanisms.

Another critical insight from the data is that organizational culture can either mitigate or intensify burnout. Several leaders discussed the cultural stigmas associated with expressing vulnerability, especially in mission-driven environments where personal sacrifice is normalized and even valorized. These findings echo recent critiques of the "self-sacrificial nonprofit hero" narrative, which can suppress help-seeking behaviors and exacerbate emotional strain (Robichau et al., 2024; Wild Apricot, 2024).

A final insight that emerged from the interviews concerns the role of volunteers in nonprofit labor dynamics. While much of the burnout literature focuses on paid staff, participants managing volunteers also described challenges related to inconsistency, emotional overload, and inadequate boundaries. These findings suggest that burnout-related concerns should not be limited to formal employees, particularly in volunteer-heavy nonprofits where the blurring of roles and responsibilities can lead to hidden labor stress. Moreover, the challenge of managing volunteer burnout without the same levers of organizational authority and accountability points to the need for differentiated strategies that still adhere to servant leadership principles (Darul Wiyono et al., 2024; De Clerck et al., 2021).

Servant Leadership in Practice

A major strength of the servant leadership behaviors described was their emphasis on emotional intelligence, particularly empathy and active listening as a counterbalance to burnout. These qualities, embedded in the servant leadership framework (Eva et al., 2019; van Dierendonck, 2011), were not only expressed as values by the interviewees but were operationalized through structured and informal practices—such as anonymous wellness surveys,

open-door policies, one-on-one debriefs, and flexible scheduling. Participants consistently employed behaviors associated with servant leadership—empathy, stewardship, listening, and commitment to employee growth (Eva et al., 2019; Walumbwa et al., 2010). The results reveal a high degree of emotional intelligence and reflexivity among nonprofit leaders. Participants demonstrated a nuanced understanding of burnout's symptoms and origins, recognizing that emotional exhaustion, disengagement, and reduced job performance are not only harmful to individual staff members but also jeopardize the fulfillment of the organization's mission. This finding aligns with Robichau et al. (2024) and Sewell et al. (2025), who emphasize that burnout is not merely a personal ailment but a systemic threat to organizational integrity.

The interviews affirm that leaders who demonstrate empathy and create psychologically safe spaces are more likely to recognize early signs of burnout and intervene before it becomes unmanageable. These findings corroborate prior research that positions servant leadership as a relational, human-centered leadership model well-suited to complex, emotionally charged environments (Darul Wiyono et al., 2024; van Dierendonck, 2011). They also expand on Obi et al. (2021), who show that effective servant leadership includes emotional regulation and well-being support mechanisms that buffer against emotional exhaustion. Importantly, leaders of smaller nonprofits appeared to have greater capacity for relational leadership, due to closer proximity to staff and more frequent informal interactions. This raises practical considerations for scaling servant leadership principles in larger organizations, where distance between leadership and frontline staff may be more pronounced. It also points to the necessity of middle-management training in empathy-based leadership strategies.

Another key contribution of this study is its demonstration that servant leadership can be enacted both formally (e.g., regular wellness check-ins, distributed leadership structures) and

informally (e.g., leaders intuiting emotional distress and initiating supportive conversations). The most successful leaders were those who not only modeled these values but embedded them into policies and everyday practices, thereby operationalizing servant leadership beyond interpersonal relationships. Practices like wellness retreats, “No Meeting Fridays,” and burnout recognition training reflect conscious efforts to replace toxic resilience norms with cultures of care and sustainability. Some participants were actively working to counter the "self-sacrificial nonprofit hero" narratives by creating spaces where vulnerability is not only accepted but expected. The findings also highlight how leaders operationalize their servant leadership values through concrete organizational practices. These include flexible work arrangements, protected time for self-care, formal wellness programs, and efforts to reshape workplace culture around openness and emotional safety. Participants, particularly from smaller organizations, emphasized the importance of tailoring interventions to individual employee needs—an approach supported by Palumbo et al. (2022) and Robichau et al. (2024), who advocate for customizable, context-sensitive burnout prevention strategies.

The data suggest that when organizations embed servant leadership values into routine operations—such as wellness surveys, no-meeting Fridays, and leadership training in trauma recognition—employee well-being is safeguarded without compromising organizational productivity. In this way, participants demonstrated that burnout mitigation is not antithetical to performance, but foundational to it. The study, therefore, reinforces the call for more holistic, systemic approaches to burnout prevention in the nonprofit sector, especially those that legitimize vulnerability and emotional support-seeking behaviors among staff (McClure & Moore, 2021; Sharp et al., 2025).

The Limits of Leadership Alone

The study's findings also raise an important question about the limits of servant leadership in addressing burnout. Participants identified several effective practices but also noted significant barriers to implementation. These barriers include limited resources, widespread uncertainty in the sector, established cultural norms that prioritize overwork, and tensions stemming from the need to balance support for both volunteers and staff. These findings reflect previous research critiquing the nonprofit sector's reliance on moral labor and voluntarism (Robichau et al., 2024; Sharp et al., 2025). Notably, there is a disconnect between leaders' desire to support staff and the systemic limitations that hinder the comprehensive implementation of wellness initiatives.

These findings support the idea that servant leadership can help reduce burnout both on interpersonal and organizational levels. However, the results also indicate that leadership alone cannot fully address systemic inequality and resource deprivation. To achieve sustainable improvements in employee well-being, burnout should be viewed as a policy issue, as well as a management issue. Leadership development efforts need to be integrated with broader organizational and policy-level changes. For servant leadership to become a truly transformative framework, it must be accompanied by advocacy for comprehensive sector-wide reforms, which include sustainable funding models, improved labor protections, and formalized employee wellness mandates (Robichau et al., 2024; McClure & Moore, 2021).

Another important contribution of this study is the documentation of the creative and adaptive strategies nonprofit leaders are using to prevent burnout and promote workplace wellness. While many of the foundational practices described by participants reflect established principles of servant leadership—such as empathy, listening, and inclusion—this study reveals

that leaders are also introducing new, context-specific initiatives in response to the evolving emotional, psychological, and professional needs of their staff. Several leaders described implementing personalized wellness practices that moved beyond generic organizational responses, such as the use of anonymous monthly wellness surveys and structural changes to the rhythm of the workweek to reduce mental fatigue. This proactive, trauma-informed strategy reflects a deeper commitment to early intervention, aligning with McClure and Moore's (2021) recommendations for trauma-informed nonprofit leadership. Rather than waiting for crises to emerge, these practices make space for staff to voice concerns before emotional distress becomes debilitating. These practices also reflect a growing awareness that time is not only a productivity metric but also a determinant of mental health—an insight supported by Palumbo et al. (2022), who emphasized time flexibility as an essential burnout prevention tool.

Some leaders proposed wellness innovations that addressed financial stressors, such as financial literacy classes and self-care stipends. Leaders also demonstrated adaptability by tailoring interventions to specific team needs. For example, using "team leads" to facilitate peer-level support and monitor wellness more closely, particularly during high-stress periods. This approach reflects distributed leadership and peer accountability—building internal leadership capacity while creating emotional safety across hierarchical levels (Rivkin et al., 2014). These proposals extend the typical boundaries of wellness interventions by acknowledging that burnout is not isolated from employees' personal lives but shaped by socioeconomic realities. In doing so, leaders expanded the scope of wellness interventions to address the material conditions that shape burnout risk, particularly relevant in the underfunded nonprofit sector (Sharp Eizinger & Roof, 2025). As such, this study supports the argument that leadership development efforts must be coupled with broader organizational and policy-level changes to create sustainable

improvements in employee well-being. These innovations also suggest a shift in nonprofit leadership culture that prioritizes experimentation, flexibility, and wellness alongside mission achievement.

Finally, the theme of iterative learning emerged across several interviews. Leaders expressed willingness to revise or abandon strategies that were ineffective and to build new initiatives collaboratively with staff input. Participant 2 reflected critically on the limited value of occasional wellness perks such as a quarterly massage, noting that such offerings lacked depth and personal relevance. Instead, they advocated for more flexible, needs-driven interventions developed in consultation with employees—a move toward a co-produced wellness culture. This evolution aligns with Gabriel and Aguinis's (2021) call for participatory practices in employee support and suggests a maturing perspective on how burnout interventions must evolve with organizational realities.

Connection to Research Question

This study enhances our understanding of burnout in the nonprofit sector by reaffirming its systemic roots, illuminating the practical relevance of servant leadership, and showing how leaders can mediate the emotional and organizational pressures that nonprofit staff endure. It builds on existing research by providing real-world examples of how leadership practices grounded in empathy and attentiveness can reshape workplace cultures and reduce burnout risk. More importantly, it reframes burnout not as an individual failure to cope but as a collective challenge requiring systemic awareness, intentional leadership, and values-based organizational design.

The findings extend current literature by documenting how nonprofit leaders are reimagining the structure of work itself as a site for well-being. A significant insight gained from

the interviews is that nonprofit leaders are not only aware of burnout's systemic causes but are actively experimenting with new tools, rhythms, and relational practices to support their staff in more personalized and sustainable ways. In doing so, they are redefining wellness as a shared organizational commitment rather than an individual responsibility, reflecting the participatory ethos emphasized in Gabriel and Aguinis's (2021) work on inclusive leadership. These findings contribute to the growing body of nonprofit leadership research by revealing how burnout prevention strategies are evolving beyond static wellness programs into dynamic, context-responsive interventions rooted in servant leadership.

This study advances the field by illustrating how nonprofit leaders are innovating within and beyond traditional servant leadership frameworks to meet the evolving needs of their staff. The analysis reveals how some leaders are embedding individualized assessment tools—such as anonymous wellness surveys and team-based emotional check-ins—into routine operations. The practices described are not merely operational tactics but reflections of a deeper shift in how nonprofit work is conceptualized: as an endeavor that must protect—not exploit—the emotional and physical labor of those who serve. They also demonstrate an intentional, trauma-informed approach to supervision that elevates emotional well-being to a position of organizational priority. Rather than relying on crisis intervention, these practices emphasize prevention, early detection, and authentic dialogue, offering a model of care that complements servant leadership's ethical commitments to empathy, listening, and stewardship (Greenleaf, 2007; Eva et al., 2019; McClure & Moore, 2021). By documenting these adaptive strategies, this research contributes both theoretically and practically to nonprofit leadership studies, organizational behavior, and burnout prevention scholarship. It also offers tangible guidance for future leadership training, workplace design, and sector-wide wellness policy reform.

Importantly, this research also documents how adaptability has become a defining feature of effective nonprofit leadership. Leaders across a range of organizational sizes and service areas showed willingness to experiment, revise, and co-create wellness strategies alongside their staff. This iterative, relational approach to leadership affirms the findings of Rivkin et al. (2014) on the positive relationship between servant leadership and employee psychological health, and it reinforces Gabriel and Aguinis's (2021) emphasis on participatory design in shaping supportive work environments. These innovations reflect a conscious reframing of time not merely as a productivity asset but as a protective factor in employee mental health. This aligns with Palumbo et al. (2022), who argue that temporal flexibility is a central condition for reducing emotional exhaustion and preserving workplace well-being in mission-driven organizations.

Another key insight is the expansion of workplace wellness to include financial and social well-being. Leaders proposed innovations such as personal finance workshops and self-care stipends, acknowledging that economic stress—especially prevalent in under-resourced nonprofit contexts—can be a significant driver of burnout (Sharp Eizinger & Roof, 2025; Wild Apricot, 2024). These proposals signal a shift from symbolic wellness gestures toward systems-informed interventions, integrating economic precarity as a legitimate target for organizational support strategies.

Implications for Practice

The findings of this study hold significant implications for nonprofit leadership practice, particularly for organizations operating in high-demand, emotionally intensive service environments. By centering the voices of nonprofit leaders and examining how they recognize and respond to employee burnout, this research offers a roadmap for interventions that are grounded in the servant leadership framework and responsive to the operational realities of

nonprofit work. First, the study underscores the critical importance of embedding emotional well-being into the core of leadership practice. Nonprofit leaders must move beyond viewing burnout as an occasional or peripheral issue and instead treat it as a central concern of organizational sustainability. Servant leadership behaviors—such as empathy, active listening, individualized support, and intentional inclusion—can significantly reduce emotional strain and promote a culture of care (Chughtai, 2018; Chen et al., 2013; Donaldson-Feilder et al., 2013). Leadership training for practitioners should therefore include a focus on relational competencies, emotional intelligence, and trauma-informed management.

Second, the findings suggest that formal wellness structures must be tailored to fit the scale and culture of the organization. Smaller nonprofits may rely on informal, high-touch practices, while larger organizations should implement formalized systems for regular staff feedback, wellness tracking, and emotional risk detection. These systems can include wellness surveys, supervision protocols, and feedback loops that allow staff to co-design interventions, as recommended by Sewell et al. (2025) and McClure and Moore (2021).

Third, strategic flexibility in time and task management emerges as a powerful burnout prevention tool. Practices like shortened meetings, remote work options, and protected time for focus reflect an organizational willingness to prioritize employee energy and autonomy—factors strongly associated with improved retention and job satisfaction (Palumbo et al., 2022; Maslach et al., 2001). Leaders should critically examine whether traditional time structures serve staff well-being or reinforce unsustainable norms.

Fourth, the research expands the scope of nonprofit wellness to include economic and social support. Burnout mitigation must consider the full spectrum of staff experience, including financial vulnerability, workload precarity, and social belonging. Proposals like financial literacy

education and self-care stipends are not peripheral luxuries but practical responses to structural stressors. They reflect a shift toward equity-informed leadership grounded in whole-person care (Robichau et al., 2024; Sharp Eizinger & Roof., 2025).

Finally, this study calls for cultural realignment within the sector. The normalization of overwork as a signal of commitment must give way to cultures that value care, boundaries, and sustainability. This shift must begin with leadership modeling—leaders who express vulnerability, protect recovery time, and advocate for realistic workloads set a precedent that reshapes organizational expectations. Board members and executive directors must see wellness not as optional but as essential to long-term impact. Together, these implications offer a path toward healthier, more resilient nonprofit organizations and provide actionable recommendations for leadership development, human resource policy, and strategic planning in mission-driven contexts.

Recommendations

The implications for practice are combined into the following evidence-based recommendations for guiding nonprofit leaders, funders, and human service organizations in cultivating healthier, more resilient workplaces that prevent burnout and enhance organizational sustainability.

Institutionalize Wellness-Oriented Leadership Development

Burnout, both on an individual and on an organizational level, can lead to poor markers of quality of life from employees and organizational performance, in terms of mission commitment, quality of work, mental health status, physical health, and employee turnover (Bayes et al., 2021; Edu-Valsania et al., 2022; Lubbadeh, 2020). As such, nonprofit organizations should embed servant leadership principles into formal leadership development

programs. Training modules should include topics such as trauma-informed supervision, emotional intelligence, conflict management, and supportive communication. Leadership pipelines must be designed to reinforce inclusive, empathetic, and relational leadership practices. Research suggests that when nonprofit leaders engage in behaviors that preserve positive affect among employees, maintain a culture that minimizes the emotional burden of individual employees, and maximize openness in communication across organizational levels, stronger organizational outcomes are likelier to result (Cianco, 2021; Cleary & Rose, 2022; Lasrado & Kassem, 2021; Muse, 2018). These approaches are widely in line with the aims of Greenleaf (2007), which seek to foreground the importance of caring for followers in a manner that emphasizes both emotional closeness and profound knowledge of the other.

Design Trauma-Responsive and Flexible Work Environments

Human services nonprofit organizations can be extremely taxing workplaces even when superbly managed, due to the emotional heft and practical complexities inherent in assisting underprivileged populations, as well as the limitations in funding (National Council of Nonprofits, 2023; Robichau et al., 2024). Given the high exposure to vicarious trauma among nonprofit staff, organizations should adopt trauma-responsive policies, such as flexible work schedules, mental health days, reduced caseloads during high-stress periods, and ongoing burnout screening. The manager may consider using coaching behaviors such as listening actively to the employee and working together with them to create developmental goals. While organizations may introduce new policies around employees' learning and development, the learning culture and the quality of the relationship between the manager and employee influence the learning and development outcomes. These practices can promote sustainability in human

service work, counteracting the patterns of toxic sacrificial obligation common in human services nonprofits (McClure & Moore, 2021; Robichau et al., 2024).

Encourage Sector-Wide Funding for Staff Well-Being

As nonprofit organizations have been widely expected to act as significant pillars of support in the face of both their public defunding and the defunding of governmental support structures, their burden of performance becomes increasingly unmanageable (Kuenzi et al., 2021; Searing et al., 2021). Foundations and government grantors should move beyond performance metrics to fund structural supports that promote organizational health, such as wellness stipends, mental health services, reflective supervision, and staff retreats. Funding agencies can model this shift by including well-being benchmarks in evaluation criteria. It is critically important that private funders, government agencies, and human services nonprofits share a vision based in a shared sense of direction and a clear understanding of feasibility in order to ensure that beneficiaries can maintain a stable level of continuity in care (Edu-Valsaia et al., 2022; Reichman, 2010; Shi et al., 2020).

Cultivate Inclusive Workplace Cultures that Destigmatize Burnout

The overwhelming importance of human services nonprofits within the grander social services sphere can drive nonprofit workers to take on greater work burdens and emotional burdens than they are capable of carrying, believing themselves to be too indispensable to the well-being of their organization and its beneficiaries to take the space needed for themselves (Kuenzi et al., 2021; Palumbo et al., 2022). These perceptions can encourage self-sacrificial behaviors that ultimately result in burnout. Cultural change must be driven from the top. Nonprofit leaders should actively normalize discussions around mental health, exhaustion, and work-life balance. This includes transparent communication, safe channels for feedback, and

reward systems that value boundary-setting and self-care alongside productivity. Research has suggested that organizational cultures that emphasize cultures of mutual support and servant leadership limit burnout, improve overall quality of employee life, increase employees' levels of workplace creativity, and labor retention (Aboramadan et al., 2022; Gabriel & Aguinis, 2021; Yan et al, 2023; Yang et al, 2017).

Develop Distinct Strategies for Volunteers and Employees

Organizations that rely on volunteer labor must develop parallel burnout-prevention strategies that acknowledge volunteers' different levels of responsibility, autonomy, and emotional exposure. Regular volunteer debriefings, task clarity, and flexible scheduling can help reduce stress and retain long-term engagement. Research has suggested that increases in servant leadership practices have positive impacts on the retention of volunteer labor in nonprofits, and that these results are particularly pronounced when combined with highly structured leadership styles (De Clerck et al., 2021; Ngah et al., 2022).

Strengths and Limitations

A key strength of this study lies in its use of semi-structured interviews, which enabled in-depth, reflective engagement with nonprofit leaders. This qualitative method facilitated the collection of rich, nuanced data, capturing not only how leaders perceive burnout but also the relational and organizational contexts that shape their leadership responses. The flexibility of the interview format allowed for tailored follow-up questions that clarified meanings and surfaced participants' lived experiences. This methodological choice aligns with best practices in qualitative inquiry for uncovering the complexity of human behavior and meaning-making in nonprofit settings (Rubin & Rubin, 2012; Tracy, 2020).

The diversity of organizational settings—ranging from volunteer-driven arts initiatives to clinical case management services—also enriched the analysis by illustrating how servant leadership practices adapt across nonprofit contexts. This variation supports the transferability of the findings and reflects the broad applicability of servant leadership principles in diverse organizational cultures (Eva et al., 2019; van Dierendonck, 2011). Grounding the study in servant leadership theory further enhanced its analytical rigor, offering a coherent conceptual framework through which to interpret leaders' behaviors and their potential influence on employee well-being. As servant leadership emphasizes empathy, listening, and stewardship (Greenleaf, 2007; Spears, 2010), it provided a natural lens through which to explore relational dimensions of burnout prevention.

Moreover, the study's findings yield actionable insights for nonprofit practitioners, funders, and policymakers by highlighting tangible strategies leaders are employing to support wellness. These include flexible scheduling, trauma-informed supervision, and participatory wellness planning. As such, the study not only contributes to theoretical knowledge but also enhances the practical understanding of how leadership can serve as a buffer against occupational burnout—an increasingly urgent concern in the nonprofit sector (Maslach & Leiter, 2016; Palumbo et al., 2022).

However, this study is not without limitations. First, the study is based on interviews with only five nonprofit leaders, all located in Illinois. While the research design prioritized depth over breadth, the small and regionally bound sample limits the generalizability of the findings to other geographic or organizational contexts. As Patton (2015) notes, qualitative insights aim for analytical, rather than statistical, generalization; nonetheless, caution should be taken when extrapolating the results.

Second, the data are based solely on self-reports from executive leaders, which introduces the risk of social desirability bias. Leaders may have portrayed their practices in more favorable terms, either consciously or unconsciously, particularly around sensitive topics like staff well-being and organizational culture (Podsakoff et al., 2003). The study did not include direct observation or triangulation through staff or volunteer interviews, which limits the ability to validate whether reported leadership strategies were experienced as effective by those most affected.

Finally, the study centers leadership perspectives without capturing the voices of frontline employees or volunteers, those most vulnerable to burnout. While leadership perspectives are essential for understanding organizational direction, omitting staff perspectives may create an incomplete picture of how wellness interventions function in practice. This limitation is especially significant in nonprofit organizations, where power dynamics and emotional labor are deeply embedded in service delivery (Brotheridge & Grandey, 2002; McClure & Moore, 2021).

Future Research Directions

This study offers several promising directions for future research. A key area involves conducting comparative analyses of leadership and burnout across different nonprofit sub-sectors, such as health and human services, the arts, education, and advocacy. Variations in funding models, organizational structures, and emotional labor demands across these subfields likely shape both leadership approaches and employee burnout in meaningful ways (Palumbo et al., 2022; McClure & Moore, 2021). Comparative research can illuminate sector-specific stressors and best practices that are often obscured in generalized nonprofit studies.

Another critical need is for longitudinal research assessing the sustained impacts of servant leadership on organizational culture and employee well-being. Most existing studies rely

on cross-sectional designs, limiting insight into causality and change over time (Eva et al., 2019; Rivkin et al., 2014). Longitudinal studies could help track whether servant leadership practices produce durable improvements in morale, reduce turnover, and foster organizational resilience—especially in high-stress, resource-constrained environments.

While some participants in this study acknowledged that burnout may be shaped by individual identity and professional role, the intersection of race, gender, and other social identities with burnout and leadership experiences remains an underexplored area. Research suggests that women, BIPOC staff, and LGBTQ+ employees often experience unique forms of emotional labor and structural disadvantage in mission-driven workspaces (Daya, 2014; Gabriel & Aguinis, 2021). Future studies should adopt an intersectional lens to explore how identity-based disparities influence the effectiveness of leadership strategies and susceptibility to burnout.

Additionally, the experiences of volunteers, who form a vital part of the nonprofit workforce, deserve deeper examination. Unlike paid staff, volunteers may lack access to organizational wellness resources or feel less empowered to express emotional fatigue. Empirical studies on volunteer burnout prevention, retention, and leadership needs remain scarce but are increasingly urgent given widespread reports of declining volunteer engagement (De Clerck et al., 2021; Ngah et al., 2022).

Lastly, future inquiry should broaden the theoretical scope by exploring alternative leadership models, including transformational, inclusive, shared, or distributed leadership, in relation to staff well-being and organizational effectiveness. Comparative research across these frameworks may uncover leadership styles that better support diverse teams, especially in multicultural or multigenerational nonprofit workplaces (Chiniara & Bentein, 2016; Hoch et al., 2018). By triangulating across sub-sector, identity, and leadership models, future scholarship can

offer a more holistic understanding of burnout mitigation and sustainable leadership in the nonprofit sector.

Final Conclusions

This study investigated the strategies that leaders of human service nonprofits within the Chicago area implement to reduce burnout risk and mitigate its consequences, with a primary focus on how servant leadership practices explain organizational approaches towards burnout. The nonprofit leaders interviewed for this study demonstrated a clear awareness of burnout's symptoms and its long-term effects on staff well-being, morale, and retention. Guided by servant leadership principles, especially empathy, stewardship, and inclusive decision-making, they developed intentional strategies to cultivate psychologically supportive workplaces. These efforts included modeling emotional transparency, maintaining open lines of communication, and adapting workloads when feasible. These findings contribute to the growing literature on nonprofit leadership by offering empirical evidence that servant leadership is not only ethically aligned with nonprofit values but also operationally effective in reducing burnout and fostering staff well-being. However, servant leadership was not applied uniformly. Leaders customized their approaches in accordance with organizational context, size, resource capacity, and staff composition, illustrating the adaptive nature of servant leadership in real-world nonprofit settings (Eva et al., 2019; Rivkin et al., 2014). These findings advance the field by demonstrating how servant leadership can be tailored to diverse nonprofit contexts and provide actionable strategies for building more resilient, inclusive, and humane organizations.

The findings reveal that burnout is not merely a product of individual workload or emotional strain but rather a systemic challenge embedded within the structural and cultural fabric of the nonprofit human services sector. Contributing factors include chronic underfunding,

the normalization of moral labor, and entrenched cultural norms that valorize self-sacrifice and overextension. These conditions intensify emotional labor demands and place sustained pressure on both staff and leaders (Grandey et al., 2013; Maslach et al., 2001; McClure & Moore, 2021). The study emphasizes the importance of continuous feedback mechanisms—such as anonymous staff surveys, reflective supervision, and structured peer debriefings—as tools for reinforcing a culture of care and responsiveness. These mechanisms enable organizations to respond dynamically to staff needs and prevent burnout from becoming entrenched.

Despite these individualized efforts, structural limitations such as constrained budgets, cultural resistance to vulnerability, and divergent staff and volunteer needs posed persistent challenges. These findings point to a critical insight: while servant leadership provides a compelling and normatively congruent model for nonprofit leadership, its success depends on more than the individual leader's behavior. Organizational culture, board engagement, funding mechanisms, and sector-level norms all influence whether servant leadership practices can be sustained and scaled (Palumbo et al., 2022; Robichau et al., 2024). To translate these findings into sustainable practice, nonprofit organizations must institutionalize wellness-oriented leadership development. This includes training emerging and existing leaders in trauma-informed supervision, emotional intelligence, and supportive communication. Boards of directors—who co-direct organizational strategy and culture—should embed staff wellness into their expectations for executive performance. Funders and donors, likewise, must revise performance assessment frameworks to support staffing, supervision, and well-being infrastructure as critical dimensions of program success (Gabriel & Aguinis, 2021; Sharp, Eizinger, & Roof, 2025).

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Appendix A

Interview Questions

1. Thank you for being here today. I really appreciate you taking the time. I read a lot about your organization and only good things, and I am amazed by the number of beneficiaries you serve and the projects you have implemented. Can you please summarize what your organization does, in your own words? Who do you serve? Who are your beneficiaries? And then how many people, the staff that you have, a number of employees?

2. Do you think your employees are burned out or at risk of getting there? If the answer is yes, then ask:

    i. "How would you describe the current level of burnout among employees in your organization?"

    ii. "Do you think the current level of employee burnout influences your organization's ability to meet its mission and objectives?"

3. How do you know they are burned out? What approach do you use to identify burnout among your employees?

4. What do the employees indicate as the primary causes of burnout, and what do you think might be a case of burnout among your staff?

5. How does your organization address the burnout issue? Or, how do you, as a leader, determine what support is most beneficial for your staff who are facing high stress or burnout? Based on the respondent's answer, choose any of the three questions listed below to clarify the leadership actions.

   i. Are there any particular approaches or practices in your organization to address/prevent employee burnout? If so, what areas do they focus on?
   ii. When thinking about employee well-being, are there specific areas you prioritize to help manage stress or workload?
   iii. How does your organization ensure employees have the time and space to recharge and maintain a healthy work-life balance?

6. What strategies or responses have you found helpful or effective, and what factors do you think contributed most to their success?

7. Can you provide any examples of when an employee's needs have influenced how you, as a leader, addressed the burnout situation?

8. Are there any particular barriers or constraints that may

   i. influence how your organization addresses burnout?

   ii. prevent employees from fully engaging with burnout-reduction initiatives?

9. Finally, what would your advice be on what additional steps nonprofit organizations could take to better address burnout?

10. Is there anything else that you would like to share that I didn't ask?

Thank you for your responses and participation in this study!

Appendix B

Definitions of Subthemes

Burnout Symptoms and Levels	Leaders' Awareness of physical and emotional indicators such as emotional exhaustion, reduced productivity, disengagement, and cynicism.
Impact on Organizational Mission	Recognition that burnout affects the organization's capacity to deliver quality services, retain staff, and achieve mission-driven outcomes.
Burnout Causes in Their Organizations	Leaders' insight into both structural and emotional sources of burnout, such as excessive workloads, multitasking, and staffing shortages inherent in nonprofit work, that contribute to burnout or/vicarious trauma resulting from continuous exposure to clients' distressing life experiences.
Empathy	Leaders' ability to understand and validate employees' emotional states and personal challenges. Active attentiveness to employee concerns, both spoken and unspoken, and willingness to adapt based on feedback.
Employee Inclusion and Growth	Commitment to nurturing staff through professional development, mentoring, recognition, and capacity building. Encouraging participation of staff in organizational decisions and valuing their input as co-creators of solutions.
Stewardship	A sense of responsibility for the overall health of the organization and well-being of its people, beyond operational duties. Intentional efforts to monitor employee Well-being to detect burnout, including formal assessments (e.g., surveys), informal feedback, and behavioral observation.
Concrete Interventions	Personalized burnout responses, such as flexible schedules, workload adjustments, and self-care support.
Work-Life Balance	Organizational efforts that protect personal time, encourage time off and regular breaks, support sustainable workloads, and protect employee time.
Wellness & Healing	Programs that build emotional resilience and team cohesion, including retreats, peer support, and resilience workshops & training, and other wellness resources; available opportunities for recovery from stress or trauma through a supportive and restorative organizational culture.
Resource Constraints	Limited financial, human, and time resources that restrict the organization's ability to implement wellness strategies.
Cultural Barriers	Organizational norms or practices that prevent employees from taking actions to disclose being stressed or burned out, a culture that nonprofit employees need to be strong to be able to help vulnerable others, or existing stigma about emotional stress or mental health issues.
Volunteer vs. Staff Differences	Specific challenges in managing burnout across different roles, particularly between paid staff and volunteers.